School Ratings and Enrollment Choices of Limited English Proficient Families: Evidence from Texas Elementary Schools

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Abstract

Public school ratings are intended to reduce the costs of acquiring and interpreting information about school quality, but their effectiveness depends on the ability of families to encounter, understand and act on the information provided. I study whether school accountability ratings affect the enrollment choices of Limited English Proficient (LEP) students, who may face greater language barriers when making school-choice decisions. I combine school accountability records with restricted student-level administrative data from Texas elementary schools and exploit statutory performance thresholds that sharply increase the probability that a school receives a higher rating. I find little evidence of an enrollment response among Hispanic LEP students at any of the three rating thresholds. At the highest rating threshold, by contrast, enrollment of non-LEP students increases by 1.9 percent and incoming transfers increase by 1.5 percentage points. More demographically comparable non-LEP groups exhibit positive but less precise responses at the lowest rating threshold, and the estimated differences between Hispanic LEP and non-LEP students are not statistically distinguishable from zero. Heterogeneity estimates suggest that Hispanic LEP enrollment increases by 7.2 percent at the lowest rating threshold in schools with above-median LEP concentration. These findings show that making school-quality information publicly available does not necessarily generate uniform behavioral responses, particularly among families facing multiple information and choice frictions.

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1 Introduction

State governments across the US routinely publish school accountability reports to make school quality information easily accessible for families. But accessing, interpreting, and evaluating school quality based on these reports might be cumbersome and costly for most parents (Hastings and Weinstein (2007); Agte et al. (2024)). Accountability ratings condense this information into a simple and salient signal of school quality. Yet the effectiveness of such transparency policies depends on whether families are able to access, understand, and act on the information being provided.

Families differ substantially in the costs of acquiring and using school-quality information. These costs may be particularly high for families of Limited English Proficient (LEP) students, who can face language barriers in addition to the typical search costs faced by other households when choosing a school. LEP families also tend to be economically disadvantaged, which can compound the barriers they face in searching for schools or acting on school-quality information. So, the LEP status captures a population facing multiple choice frictions rather than language barriers alone. This population is also policy relevant because education agencies often make deliberate efforts to make school choice information accessible to linguistic groups through translated material, multilingual enrollment assistance, explanatory guidance and other forms of decision support. Therefore, whether LEP families find school rating sufficient to generate behavioral responses is an important question.

A simple categorical rating could reduce some of the costs of acquiring and processing school quality information. However, if the costs of learning about, interpreting or acting on the rating itself are particularly high for many LEP families, accountability policies may be less effective at informing those that could benefit the most from it. This tension in the school accountability policy remains the focus of this study.

The paper asks whether school accountability ratings affect school choice decisions by LEP families as evidenced by their enrollment choices. I study Texas elementary schools between 2001 and 2008, when the state's accountability system assigned schools to one of four categorical ratings based on predetermined performance thresholds. This

setting is useful for several reasons. First, Texas was one of the earliest adopters of the accountability system dating back to early 1990s. So, by the study period, the accountability system was well established and ratings were routinely produced and publicly reported. Second, the accountability formula used by Texas during this period generates discrete changes in a school rating around continuous measures of underlying performance, which forms the basis of the empirical approach followed in this study.

I exploit the rating thresholds in a regression discontinuity design to isolate the causal effect of receiving a higher accountability rating. Schools immediately above and below a threshold have similar underlying performance but receive different categorical signals about school quality. So, comparing enrollment outcomes around these cutoffs allows me to distinguish responses to the public rating from responses to the underlying characteristics that determine school performance. As with all studies following a regression discontinuity design, it is important to note that the design only examines whether the categorical label itself changes behavior among schools with very similar underlying performance. It does not test whether families respond to larger differences in school quality or to ratings when schools are farther apart in the underlying distribution. The analysis focuses on Hispanic LEP students and benchmarks their enrollment responses against three non-LEP groups. All non-LEP students provide a broad comparison with the rest of the student population, Hispanic non-LEP students provide a comparison along racial and ethnic dimensions and may also be exposed to similar community and parental information networks, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students provide a socioeconomic benchmark given the high rate of economic disadvantage among Hispanic LEP students. I then test whether the estimated responses differ across these groups.

The raw enrollment patterns are highly correlated with accountability ratings. Enrollment change as a proportion of baseline enrollment increases systematically with school ratings for Hispanic LEP students, which make up a majority of LEP students. Meanwhile, the enrollment growth of Hispanic non-LEP students, which is an ethnically-comparable group, is much more uniform across rating categories. As a result, the difference in enrollment growth between Hispanic LEP and Hispanic non-LEP students

is increasingly positive at higher rating levels. Taken at face value, these estimates suggest that Hispanic LEP families were sorting sharply towards better-rated schools. However, schools receiving different ratings also differ systematically in several factors such as student composition, neighborhood characteristics, socioeconomic status, and the underlying quality and availability of schooling options. So, simple comparisons across rating categories therefore cannot isolate the informational effect of the rating itself.

Using a regression discontinuity design, I find that the differences in response disappear. I find little evidence of a discontinuous response among Hispanic LEP students at any of the three rating thresholds. This contrasts with the positive and relatively robust increase in enrollment and incoming transfers of the broader non-LEP student population at the Exemplary threshold. However, among Hispanic non-LEP and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students, who are a more demographically comparable benchmark to Hispanic LEP students, the estimates are also positive for enrollment growth and incoming transfers at the Acceptable threshold but are imprecise and sensitive to bandwidth choice. At the other rating thresholds, these groups also show little evidence of enrollment response. Taken together, the results show a weak response to school rating labels among Hispanic LEP students while the evidence of a differential response among other groups of non-LEP students is more suggestive than conclusive.

Even though the ratings and the underlying pass rates that determine the rating are public, the question remains why the Hispanic LEP families show little response to crossing the rating threshold. There could at least be three possible reasons. First, the ratings may not reach or be salient to these families. Second, families may be aware of the ratings but face constraints that limit their ability to act on it. These could be financial constraints or limited choice of schools around them. Third, families may be aware of the ratings and have the ability to respond but place a greater weight on other school characteristics such as peer quality when making enrollment decisions. Finally, families could also be aware of the underlying pass rate either for the school or for their own demographic group and might not find the rating informative. Although the data does not allow me to distinguish between these channels directly, I assess whether the weak average response varies across different school environments in ways that can be

informative about some of these explanations.

I first examine whether LEP families are more responsive when they have more schooling choice within their district. There seems to be little evidence that Hispanic LEP students respond more strongly in districts with an above-median number of schools. Second, I test their responsiveness when they are surrounded by a larger population of students from the same background. In schools with an above-median LEP enrollment share at baseline, the Hispanic LEP enrollment significantly increases by 7.2 percentage points on average at the Acceptable threshold, which is significant at the 10 percent level. Although this response is not statistically different from the estimate at schools with below-median LEP share, it suggested that the overall null does not reflect a complete lack of responsiveness to accountability ratings among Hispanic LEP households but appears to vary with the environment in which families encounter and act on the rating.

These findings show that publicly available information on school quality does not necessarily generate the same behavioral response across families. The positive enrollment response among some non-LEP comparison groups shows that the ratings have an effect on school choice decisions but the weak average response among Hispanic LEP families suggests that the same signal can have a limited influence on some groups. At the same time, the stronger response among Hispanic LEP students in high-LEP schools suggests that the response could depend on the environment in which families encounter the rating. Overall, the results highlight that the effectiveness of school accountability policies depend not only on the information it contains but also on whether families encounter, attend to, interpret, and are able to act on that information.

This paper contributes first to a literature showing that school accountability systems affect student achievement and educator behavior (Neal and Schanzenbach, 2010; Dee and Jacob, 2011; Cullen et al., 2024). My study complements this work by examining the enrollment decision of families as another margin through which accountability systems could matter.

A related literature shows that families respond to information about school quality. Studies show that school ratings affect residential sorting and housing prices while interventions that directly provide families with school-performance information can

alter school choices and enrollment outcomes (Figlio and Lucas, 2004; Hastings and Weinstein, 2007; Andrabi et al., 2017). More recently, (Corradini, 2024) shows that introducing letter grades for New York high schools shifted school choices for Black and Hispanic students more strongly than white and Asian students. My setting differs from most of the literature in two ways. The students in Texas during the study period were assigned to neighborhood schools rather than being able to choose through a centralized assignment system. And the information in this setting is publicly released through an existing accountability system and is less salient than being delivered to them through a direct intervention. This allows me to study whether a common public signal generates similar enrollment responses among families who may differ in the barriers they face when accessing and acting on school-quality information.

Some recent work suggests that students classified as English learners respond strongly to school quality information when it directly provided to them. Cohodes et al. (2025) find that English learners were the strongest responders to informational intervention in New York City high schools. Interestingly, this stands in contrast with my setting where Hispanic LEP families show little average response to publicly-available school ratings.

Finally, this study extends the literature on English learners. Most of the research work until now has examined the policies that directly affect the education environment of these student, including provision of bilingual education (Chin et al. (2013)) or the reclassification out of English-learner status (Carlson and Knowles (2016)). I shift the focus from curriculum or programs that specifically target LEP students to how families of LEP students use general information about overall school quality.

Broadly, this paper takes the literature forward by studying who responds to a simplified public signal of school quality in a context where acquiring and acting on information may be costly. Unlike much of the literature that uses information-related interventions, the setting in this study does not include a centralized choice process or direct provision of information to families. Instead, the research design isolates the local effect of a categorical rating in a neighborhood-based system of schooling and examines how the response varies by LEP status and across different school environments.

2 Institutional Setting and Data

2.1 The Texas School Accountability System

Texas was one of the earliest adopters of a school accountability system. By the early 2000s, which is the period of focus in this study, the Texas Education Agency (TEA) annually assigned each public school a categorical rating that was primarily based on student performance on state-wide standardized exams. These ratings were made public by being posted online and every school was mandated to provide a copy of the accountability report to parents. They were available in English and Spanish languages. An example of the information provided in these reports is shown in Figure A1. The school accountability rating on top of the report card is a relatively coarse but salient summary of the school performance in contrast to the test score performance reported along with it. The ratings also received widespread media coverage and publication alongside real estate listings.

In this study, I focus on Texas elementary school from 2000-01 through 2007-08 academic years. For convenience, I will refer to an academic year by its ending year. I exclude 2003 from the analysis as Texas was transitioning to a different testing system and no ratings were published in that year. In all remaining years, schools were classified into one of four rating categories: Unacceptable, Acceptable, Recognized, or Exemplary.

The rating was determined using pass rates on standardized tests for multiple subjects. The tested subjects included mathematics and reading in grades 3 through 6, writing in grade 4, and science in grade 5. Each school's performance is evaluated separately for all students, Hispanic students, White students, Black students, and economically-disadvantaged students. A group except all students was only included if they exceeded the minimum size requirement, which was typically 30 students. The pass rates of each eligible subject-by-group was compared with statutory performance thresholds that varied by accountability level and across years. The threshold for exemplary rating was typically a pass rate of 90 percent; the recognized threshold ranged from 70 to 80 percent; while the acceptable threshold was lower and varied across subjects and years.

The accountability system was designed to incentivize schools to focus on all subjects

and students - especially the low-performing groups. It effectively imposed a minimum-performance rule where a school's overall rating could be no higher than the performance of its lowest-performing subject-by-group. I refer to the eligible subject-by-group cell with the lowest pass rate as the school's *marginal group*. This feature of the system is central to the empirical design because it allows school performance to be summarized relative to the statutory cutoff relevant for a particular accountability margin.

The system also included additional provisions to reward improvement and address circumstances perceived to unfairly disadvantage some schools. The rules allowed schools that fell short of a performance threshold to qualify for a higher rating under *required improvement* provisions when performance had improved sufficiently relative to the prior year. Further, recognizing that more subgroups increase the probability of a low rating for a given overall distribution of student knowledge, schools could also receive a limited number of *exceptions* when particular measures narrowly failed to satisfy the relevant standard. There were restrictions to use of required improvements and exceptions. For example, a subgroup could not be exempted two years in a row. Also, these provisions could not be used to obtain an Exemplary rating.

I incorporate these provisions when reconstructing each school's accountability rating. For every school-year, I calculate performance for each eligible subject-by-student group, apply the contemporaneous statutory thresholds, required-improvement provisions, and exception rules, and assign the final rating implied by the full accountability formula. I then identify the marginal group and measure its performance relative to the statutory cutoff associated with each rating margin. Thus, separate running variables can be constructed for the Unacceptable-to-Acceptable, Acceptable-to-Recognized, and Recognized-to-Exemplary margins.

These rules generate the identifying variation used in the paper. Schools with marginal-group performance just above and just below a statutory cutoff have very similar underlying test performance but face a discontinuous change in their likelihood of receiving the higher accountability rating. Because required-improvement and exception provisions can affect the final rating, crossing the statutory threshold does not mechanically determine treatment in every case.

2.2 Data and Sample

I combine two primary sources of data for this study. First, I use the Texas Academic Excellence Indicator System (AEIS), which contains indicators on school accountability ratings and the pass rates used to calculate them. I reconstruct the school ratings and identify the demographic group that determines the relevant rating threshold for each school in each year based on the rating process followed in Cullen et al. (2024). Second, I use the restricted student-level administrative records from the Texas Education Agency (TEA) provided by the Education Research Center (ERC) at the University of Texas at Dallas Texas Schools Project. The data allows me to follow students longitudinally across schools in Texas and contains information on their enrollment, academic performance and demographic characteristics. I use this data to create the outcome indicators on student mobility across schools.

The focus of the study is on Limited English Proficient (LEP) students. During the period I study, Texas identified LEP students through state-approved oral language proficiency tests. I classify a student as LEP if they are observed as Limited English Proficient at any point in the dataset during the sample period. A student who is never observed with a LEP classification is categorized as non-LEP. LEP students account for 29.2 percent of the total enrollment in my sample. Among LEP students, 91.5 percent are Hispanic and 94.6 percent are ever eligible for free or reduced-price lunch. In comparison, only 31 percent of non-LEP students are Hispanic and 63.7 percent of them are ever eligible for free or reduced-price lunch. I refer to the latter measure as *economically disadvantaged* henceforth in this paper.

Since LEP students in Texas are predominantly Hispanic, my main analysis will focus on them and will compare their outcomes to three non-LEP students. First, I use all non-LEP students as a broad benchmark to examine whether Hispanic LEP families respond differently from the rest of the student population. Next, I compare them to Hispanic non-LEP students for a more comparable group along racial and ethic dimensions and potentially also in their exposure to community and parental information networks. Finally, since Hispanic LEP students are overwhelmingly economically disadvantaged, I compare them with economically disadvantaged non-LEP students as well to provide a

benchmark that is more similar along the socioeconomic dimension.

Table 1 reports the characteristics of Hispanic LEP and the =comparison groups in the analysis sample. Panel A shows that 97.4 percent of Hispanic LEP students are economically disadvantaged, which is substantially more than 63.6 percent of all non-LEP students and 84.8 percent for Hispanic non-LEP students. Hispanic LEP students are also slightly more concentrated in urban areas with 61.4 percent attending urban schools compared to all three non-LEP comparison groups.

Panel B shows the groups are distributed differently across accountability categories. Among Hispanic LEP students, more than half are enrolled in schools rated Acceptable while only 7.3 percent attended school rated Exemplary. In comparison, among all non-LEP students, the corresponding figures are 34.3 percent and 19.3 percent respectively. The distribution of economically disadvantaged non-LEP is the closest to the Hispanic LEP distribution. These descriptive differences show that LEP status of students is correlated with school-level characteristics and their exposure to accountability ratings. So, simply comparing enrollment behavior across rating categories may reflect underlying differences in student and school characteristics rather than causal effect of the rating itself. This motivates the regression discontinuity design outlined in Section 3.

2.3 Measuring Enrollment Responses

The outcomes of interest in this study are designed to capture the changes in revealed preference for a school following the publication of its accountability rating. Since the focus is on change, it is important to be careful about timing in this setting. A rating is published based on tests administered in academic year t in the early months of the academic year $t+1$. Since enrollment decisions are already made by the time ratings are published, I measure enrollment outcomes in year $t+2$. This allows parents sufficient time to observe and respond to the rating.

The primary outcome for the study is enrollment change between year t and $t+2$. This measure captures the net change in group-specific enrollment between the rating year and the post-rating enrollment year. The remaining outcomes distinguish the different channels of enrollment change. While isolating the channels, it is important

to distinguish between incumbent and prospective families. Families whose children are already enrolled in a school will observe many aspects of quality directly making the rating received by the school potentially less informative for them. Therefore, we might expect families considering entry into a school might place a higher weight on public ratings. For this reason, while the study investigates both entry and exit margins, the former is particularly interesting.

An important complication is that many school changes are structural in nature. For example, students moving out of a feeder school after graduating from a terminal grade should not be seen as a response to a school rating. Therefore, I only focus on *nonstructural* moves in the entry and exit outcome measures. Additionally, I restrict the sample to schools that offer the same set of grades between year $t-2$ and the outcome year $t+2$. This ensures that changes in the school's grade configuration does not mechanically generate large changes in enrollment and helps isolate enrollment shifts that are more likely to reflect active choices of families.

I separate entry into *incoming transfers* and *new entrants* to distinguish families based on their possible level of familiarity with the Texas school system. To identify incoming transfers, I follow a student observed in year t from their school to another school in year $t+2$. I classify an incoming transfer as a structural transition when more than 35 percent of the origin cohort moves to the same destination. I exclude these flows and define incoming transfer as students arriving at a focal school through remaining nonstructural flows. This helps me isolate lateral student movement that is more likely an active schooling choice. I separately define new entrants as students enrolled at the focal school in $t+2$ who were not observed in the Texas public school system in t. These families could be either enrolling their children at pre-kindergarten level or entering Texas public schools for the first time.

Finally, I define *leavers* as students who were enrolled at the focal school in t but are no longer enrolled there in $t+2$. In this case, I exclude structural leavers by excluding students who are in the school's terminal grade or one year below the terminal grade in t since the outcome horizon spans over two years and both groups are expected to graduate out of the school by $t+2$.

I normalize all outcome variables by the group's enrollment at the school in the baseline year. So, the resulting estimates can be interpreted as changes relative to the baseline group enrollment.

2.4 Descriptive Enrollment Patterns

Figure 1 presents raw mobility patterns by accountability rating for all outcome variables. The enrollment growth pattern varies sharply by rating category and also differs for Hispanic LEP and Hispanic non-LEP students. The same holds true on the entry margin as well, especially for incoming transfers. However, these differences in mobility cannot be attributed to school rating labels since there are systematic differences in the schools and the types of students enrolled in these schools. Therefore, I turn to a regression discontinuity design to isolate the true effect of the rating.

3 Empirical Strategy

3.1 Identification Strategy

The primary challenge in understanding the effect of school rating on enrollment outcomes of students is that schools of different rating categories also differ in other meaningful factors such as neighborhood characteristics, quality of teachers and peers, parental resources and so on. A comparison of enrollment outcomes across rating categories will therefore confound true responses to accountability ratings with these underlying differences.

I address this challenge by using a regression discontinuity (RD) design based on the unique accountability framework followed by Texas during the sample period. As described in Section 2.1, a school's rating was typically determined by the performance of the lowest performing subject-by-demographic group. In this setting, schools whose marginal group pass rates fall just above and below a threshold are of similar underlying quality but face a discrete change in the probability of receiving a higher accountability rating. The resulting discontinuity can be exploited to isolate the variation in the public signal of school quality.

I construct a separate running variable based on the pass rate of the marginal group

for each of the three rating thresholds: Unacceptable-Acceptable, Acceptable-Recognized, and Recognized-Exemplary. I will refer to these as the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary thresholds.

Let p_{st} denote the pass rate of the marginal group for school s in year t, and let c_{st}^k denote the statutory threshold that applies at rating margin $k \in \{A, R, E\}$. I define

$$R_{st}^k = p_{st} - c_{st}^k. \tag{1}$$

The running variable is centered at zero. So, schools with $R_{st}^k < 0$ fall below the statutory threshold and schools with $R_{st}^k \geq 0$ meet or exceed it.

Each school's rating and marginal group is reconstructed using the full accountability assignment rules based on Cullen et al. (2024), including the statutory pass-rate thresholds, required-improvement provisions, and exceptions. The reconstructed assignment rule predicts approximately 98 percent of observed school ratings. Since crossing the statutory threshold changes the probability of receiving the higher rating but does not perfectly determine the observed rating, the realized rating exhibits a fuzzy discontinuity at the cutoff. Consequently, all reported estimates are intent-to-treat effects.

3.2 Estimation

For each rating margin, I estimate the following local-linear reduced-form specification:

$$Y_{sdt} = \alpha + \beta \mathbb{1}\{R_{sdt}^k \geq 0\} + \gamma_1 R_{sdt}^k + \gamma_2 \mathbb{1}\{R_{sdt}^k \geq 0\} \times R_{sdt}^k + \varepsilon_{sdt}, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{sdt} is an enrollment or mobility outcome for school s in district d in year t, and R_{sdt}^k is the centered running variable for rating margin k. The coefficients γ_1 and γ_2 allows the relationship between the outcome and the running variable to differ on either side of the threshold.

The coefficient of interest, β, measures the discontinuous change in the outcome when the school's marginal-group pass rate crosses the statutory rating threshold. I estimate Equation 2 separately at the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary margins and separately for Hispanic LEP and all three comparison non-LEP groups. The baseline

specification uses observations within eight percentage points of the relevant cutoff and clusters standard errors at the campus level. This choice is made to provide a relatively local comparison around each statutory threshold while retaining enough observations for a reasonably precise estimation, particularly around the Acceptable threshold where the local sample is substantially small. I also support my results by showing sensitivity to other bandwidths. Because the outcomes are normalized by the corresponding group's year-t enrollment, multiplying the coefficients by 100 expresses the response as percentage of the baseline group enrollment.

The corresponding first-stage specification is:

$$D^k_{sdt} = \pi_0 + \pi_1 \mathbb{1}\{R^k_{sdt} \geq 0\} + \pi_2 R^k_{sdt} + \pi_3 \mathbb{1}\{R^k_{sdt} \geq 0\} \times R^k_{sdt} + u_{sdt}, \tag{3}$$

where D^k_{sdt} indicates whether the school receives a rating at or above the relevant category. The coefficient π_1 measures the discontinuous change in the probability of receiving the higher rating at the statutory cutoff.

Figure 2 presents the first stage for each of the three rating margins. At all three thresholds, crossing the statutory cutoff produces a large increase in the probability that a school receives the higher accountability rating. The discontinuity is particularly sharp at the Recognized and Exemplary thresholds, where crossing the cutoff increases the probability of receiving the higher rating by approximately 98.0 and 95.3 percentage points, respectively. The first stage at the Acceptable threshold is also large but the assignment is somewhat less sharp at about 88.3 percentage points. Although I incorporate the detailed and time-varying accountability rules when reconstructing school ratings, the reconstructed ratings do not perfectly predict the realized rating for a small share of schools. This imperfect prediction generates a fuzzy rather than sharp regression discontinuity design. Overall, the plots confirm that the statutory thresholds generate strong discontinuities in the public rating received by schools. Given the strong first stage, the implied Local Average Treatment Effects (LATE) are quantitatively similar to the reduced form estimates, which is what I report throughout the paper.

3.3 Identification and Validity

The validity of this RD design depends on the assumption that in the absence of the discrete change in the accountability rating, potential enrollment outcomes vary smoothly through the rating threshold (Lee and Lemieux, 2010; Cattaneo and Titiunik, 2022). This condition would be violated if schools could precisely manipulate their position relative to the cutoff or if other determinants of student mobility changed discontinuously at the threshold.

A key evidence against precise manipulation is that schools should not be able to cluster above the cutoff (McCrary, 2008). Figure 3 plots the distribution of the running variable around each of the three rating thresholds. I do not observe an obvious discontinuity or bunching above zero at any of the cutoffs. While the distribution varies over the wider support of the running variable, its local behavior around the threshold provides no clear visual evidence of precise sorting. Further, given the complex nature of the rating mechanism, it is difficult for any school to precisely manipulate their position around the cutoffs.

As a second assessment of the identifying assumption, I test whether predetermined school and enrollment characteristics vary discontinuously at the rating thresholds. Table 2 reports these balance tests. Each entry reports the estimated discontinuity at the relevant cutoff within a bandwidth of 8 percentage points and the mean of the corresponding variable is reported below. The table shows that predetermined school characteristics are generally smooth around the rating thresholds. I find no differences in the fraction of urban or suburban schools and the fraction of students that are Hispanic or LEP in the sample of schools that receive a lower rating versus those that narrowly receive a higher rating across any of the three thresholds. The group-specific enrollment characteristics are also generally balanced. For Hispanic LEP students, neither baseline enrollment nor proportional enrollment growth between $t-2$ and t changes significantly at any threshold. The three non-LEP comparison groups also seem balanced around the Acceptable and Exemplary threshold. The only exception appears around the Recognized threshold where the baseline enrollment for non-LEP students is 17.8 students higher just above the cutoff and the pre-period enrollment growth is 2 percentage points higher

and both estimates are statistically significant.The pre-period growth estimates are also positive for Hispanic non-LEP and economically disadvantaged non-LEP at 3 and 2 percentage points respectively. However, only the latter is statistically significant. Appendix Table A1 presents the same balance table using a bandwidth of four percentage points around the threshold. The non-LEP imbalance around the Recognized threshold seems persistent for all non-LEP and Hispanic non-LEP at the lower bandwidth as well. So, I interpret the non-LEP estimates along this margin more cautiously and examine their sensitivity to alternative bandwidths and specifications.

4 Main Results

4.1 Enrollment Responses to Accountability Ratings

The reduced form effects of crossing each accountability threshold on enrollment change are shown in Table 3. The first column reports estimates for Hispanic LEP students while the remaining columns provide three non-LEP benchmarks. All non-LEP students in the second column provide a broad comparison with the rest of the student population. The third column compares Hispanic LEP with Hispanic non-LEP students, holding ethnicity constant while allowing LEP status to differ. Finally, the fourth column shows the comparison with economically disadvantaged non-LEP students, holding the economic status nearly constant as Hispanic LEP students are also predominantly low-income as shown in Table 1, while allowing ethnicity to differ.

For Hispanic LEP students, there appears to be little evidence of an enrollment response at any of the three rating thresholds. Crossing the Acceptable threshold increases Hispanic LEP enrollment by 2.7 percent relative to baseline enrollment, but the estimate is imprecise and statistically indistinguishable from zero. In contrast, the point estimates are positive and larger for all three non-LEP comparison groups at 5.4 percent for the all non-LEP students, 16.5 percent for Hispanic non-LEP students and 4.3 percent for economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. While only the Hispanic non-LEP estimate is significantly different from zero, the broader pattern of the comparison groups contrasts with the smaller Hispanic LEP response. The relatively large Hispanic non-LEP response, however, should be interpreted with caution as the sample size around the

Acceptable threshold is relatively small compared to other cutoffs and the estimates are less stable across alternative bandwidths as shown in Appendix Table A2. Finally, the Hispanic LEP estimates at the Recognized and Exemplary thresholds are -1.9 and -3.1 percent, respectively, and are also statistically insignificant. However, the response of all non-LEP and Hispanic non-LEP students at the Exemplary threshold is positive at 1.9 percent an 2.3 percent, respectively. In fact, the former is significantly different from zero.

Figure 4 provides the graphical counterpart to the estimates at the Acceptable threshold. The fitted relationships show a positive shift at the cutoff for each of the three non-LEP groups compared to a smaller shift for Hispanic LEP students. Although the estimates for all non-LEP and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students are not statistically distinguishable from zero, the common direction of the graphical and regression estimates is consistent with greater responsiveness among the non-LEP comparison groups at the Acceptable threshold.

The graphical evidence at other thresholds is also consistent with the regression estimates. Figure 5 does not show meaningful evidence of discontinuity for any of the groups at the Recognized threshold. On the other hand, at the Exemplary threshold, Figure 6 shows a visible positive shift for all non-LEP and Hispanic non-LEP while the Hispanic LEP enrollment change shows a negative effect as discussed before.

Appendix Table A2 examines the sensitivity of these estimates to alternate bandwidths. The Hispanic LEP seem noisy around the Acceptable threshold and consistently negative at Recognized and Exemplary thresholds. On the other hand, the response of all non-LEP students is consistently positive at all thresholds and particularly stable and significant at the Exemplary cutoff. The same holds true for Hispanic non-LEP and economically disadvantaged non-LEP at the Exemplary threshold as well.

The key takeaway is that the enrollment response to rating is more muted for Hispanic LEP students relative to some of the comparison groups. Even at the Exemplary threshold where the enrollment for all non-LEP students increases by 1.9 percent in the baseline specification, the estimate for Hispanic LEP students is negative and not statistically different from zero.

While these estimates and the graphical evidence suggest that Hispanic LEP students may respond less strongly to accountability ratings than some non-LEP students, I test whether the effects for LEP versus all comparison groups are statistically different in Table 4. Although none of the differences are statistically significant, almost all of the estimated gap between Hispanic LEP and the comparison groups are negative, which reflects the smaller Hispanic LEP response. The gaps are also generally smaller across most thresholds when the comparison group is economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. For example, at the Exemplary threshold, the estimated gap between the two groups is only 3.8 percentage points compared to 5 percentage points relative to all non-LEP students and 5.5 percentage points relative to Hispanic non-LEP students. Since Hispanic LEP and economically disadvantaged non-LEP are more similar in their socio-economic circumstances, the smaller gaps between these groups are consistent with resource constraints accounting for part of the difference between Hispanic LEP and the broader non-LEP student population. Low-income families may share constraints such as challenges in incurring mobility costs, fewer feasible housing alternatives, and a more limited set of schooling options. Hispanic LEP families may face these constraints in addition to language-related barriers when making schooling decisions.

Taken together, these estimates do not provide statistically precise evidence that Hispanic LEP students respond differently to accountability ratings than non-LEP students. The point estimates, however, are consistent with a more muted response among Hispanic LEP students relative to the broader non-LEP population at some rating margins, particularly the Exemplary threshold. At the same time, the differences are noticeably smaller when the comparison group is restricted to economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. This suggests that part of the contrast between Hispanic LEP and all non-LEP students may reflect differences in socioeconomic composition rather than LEP status alone.

4.2 Enrollment Channels

I next examine whether the enrollment responses operate through entry into the Texas public school system, or students leaving the school. Table 5 reports the RD estimates for

each of these three margins. I treat these outcomes as secondary to the overall enrollment change measure. Enrollment change captures the net effect of student mobility, whereas the channel outcomes measure gross flows and are therefore more sensitive to differences in the overall level of student turnover across schools.

The clearest pattern appears for incoming transfers. At the Acceptable threshold, crossing the cutoff significantly increases the incoming transfers for all three comparison groups. It increases by 9.5 percentage points for all non-LEP students, 17.7 percentage points for Hispanic non-LEP students, and 10.3 percentage points for economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. By contrast, the corresponding estimate for Hispanic LEP students is much smaller at 3.3 percentage points and statistically insignificant. At the Exemplary threshold, incoming transfers also increase by 1.5 percentage points for all non-LEP students while the Hispanic LEP estimate is negative and imprecise. There is little evidence of an incoming transfer response at the Recognized threshold for any group of students.

The remaining mobility margins show considerably weaker responses. I find no statistically significant effect on new entrants for Hispanic LEP students or for the broader non-LEP comparison groups at any threshold. Similarly, the leaver estimates are generally small and statistically indistinguishable from zero. Thus, the non-LEP enrollment response to the rating comes strongly from students transferring schools but Hispanic LEP students remain unresponsive even on that front.

Appendix Table A3 shows the robustness of the incoming transfer effects to bandwidth selection. The positive effects for non-LEP students are robust to alternative bandwidths. The estimates lose statistical significance when using a bandwidth of 4 but are qualitatively similar. Similarly, I find no meaningful responses for Hispanic LEP students across any of the bandwidths.

Overall, the main results reveal that Hispanic LEP enrollment does not exhibit a notable response in enrollment to crossing the accountability thresholds, while some non-LEP groups respond positively on some margins through incoming transfers between schools.

The absence of a precisely estimated enrollment response among Hispanic LEP

students does not tell us why these families appear less responsive to accountability ratings. One explanation could be that families also observe the underlying pass rate information and recognize that schools below and above the cutoff are similar in quality. In such a case families would place little weight on the rating as a signal of school quality. I cannot rule out this possibility but this mechanism would attentuate response across all families. But we do see some response from non-LEP families. So, unless Hispanic LEP families are more likely to access the underlying pass rate information, this explanation is unlikely. Therefore, I focus on mechanisms that could more directly generate a differential response among Hispanic LEP families.

First, families may face information frictions that limit whether they receive the rating signal. Prior work documents limited awareness of available schools (Agte et al., 2024), misperceptions about school quality (Agte et al., 2024; Ainsworth et al., 2023), high costs of acquiring and processing school-quality information (Hastings and Weinstein, 2007), and low engagement with information when it is available but not actively delivered or made salient (Cohodes et al., 2025). Second, families may observe the rating but face constraints that limit their ability to respond by changing schools. These constraints could be financial as it is costly to move neighborhoods for schooling or institutional as there might be limited schools in proximity, especially ones that cater to needs of LEP families. Burgess et al. (2015) has shown that proximity and admission constraints substantially limit the school choice sets of families. Third, families could be aware of the rating and have the resources to respond but evaluate school quality along dimensions that are not fully captured by the test-based accountability framework. For example, Abdulkadiroğlu et al. (2020) find that parents place a considerable weight on peer quality when choosing schools while Beuermann et al. (2023) shows that parents of low-achieving students strongly value the impact of schools on outcomes beyond test scores. In the context of this study, the school choice preference of Hispanic LEP families might be correlated with the share of students from similar backgrounds in the school.

The available data do not allow me to distinguish cleanly among these mechanisms. Instead, I examine whether responsiveness varies across school environments in ways that are informative about some of these possibilities. I first consider the local choice

environment. If limited schooling options constrain families' ability to respond to new information, ratings should have greater scope to affect enrollment in districts with multiple elementary schools than in districts where families have few within-district alternatives. I then examine heterogeneity by the concentration of LEP students in the school. Schools with a high share of LEP students differ in the presence of Spanish-speaking families and may additionally differ in the availability of language-related programs. If these features make a school more attractive to LEP families, the enrollment response to crossing a rating threshold should be higher in schools with higher share of LEP students. The resulting estimates should therefore be interpreted as evidence on how responsiveness varies across school environments rather than as tests of a single mechanism.

5 Heterogeneity Results

I examine whether the enrollment response varies across two dimensions of the school environment: the local choice set as defined by within-district school availability and the concentration of LEP students in the school.

The first dimension captures the differences in the number of schooling options within an administrative district. I classify districts according to whether the number of elementary schools is above the district-level median. The idea behind this split is to capture differences in the local schooling options available to families. Ideally, this would be measured using the number of elementary schools located close to a family's place of residence. But I do not observe school district boundaries or precise residential choice sets in my data. So, I use the number of elementary schools in the administrative district as a proxy for the set of nearby schooling options available to families.

This measure does not imply that families can freely choose among all schools in the district. The schools in my setting are traditional public schools. So, families generally need to change their residence to enroll in a different school. Nevertheless, it may be more feasible to switch to another school within the same district when the district contains more elementary schools. Families may be able to remain within the same broader commuting area and may also have more information about nearby

neighborhoods and schools within their district. Therefore, enrollment responses to ratings could be stronger in districts with more elementary schools than in districts with few within-district alternatives. Thus, if limited schooling options are leading to muted average response from Hispanic LEP families, their response should be stronger in districts with greater within-district school availability.

The second dimension is the concentration of LEP students within the school. A higher share of LEP students is associated with the presence of a larger community of families with similar linguistic backgrounds, which could drive stronger parental information networks, and may also be associated with features of the school environment that are particularly relevant for LEP families, including language-related programs and resources. These features could affect either how information about school ratings is transmitted or families' willingness to move in response to the rating. I do not observe these mechanisms directly, so the split tests whether the causal effect of the rating varies with LEP concentration but does not identify the causal effect of LEP concentration itself.

Before presenting the heterogeneity estimates, Table 6 shows how these environments differ along observable dimensions. Panel A compares districts with above and below-median within-district school availability. The differences are substantial. Districts in the lower-availability group have one elementary school on average, compared with approximately 43 schools in the above-median group. Schools in districts with greater availability are also substantially larger and more urban. The average enrollment in above-median availability districts is 612 students compared with 342 in below-median districts, and 52.5 percent of schools are urban compared with only 4.2 percent in the lower-availability group. They also have higher LEP shares, at 28.8 percent compared with 10.6 percent, while economically disadvantaged shares are relatively similar across the two groups. Thus, the school-availability split not only captures the number of available schools but also broader differences between large, predominantly urban districts and smaller, more rural districts.

Panel B shows that high-LEP schools also differ considerably from low-LEP schools. By construction, the LEP share is substantially higher, at 45.3 percent compared with

7.2 percent in low-LEP schools. High-LEP schools are also larger, more urban, and more economically disadvantaged. They are located in districts with more elementary schools as well. The average high-LEP school is in a district with approximately 50 elementary schools compared with 23 among low-LEP schools. Thus, LEP concentration is correlated with both the demographic composition of the school and the local schooling environment. As a result, I interpret the heterogeneity results as causal effects of crossing the rating threshold within different observed school environments. They show whether the effect of the rating varies with school availability or LEP concentration but do not identify the causal effect of those environment characteristics themselves.

Table 7 reports the RD estimates separately by these school environments for all four student groups. Panel A presents estimates by within-district school availability. Among Hispanic LEP students, there is little evidence that the enrollment response becomes stronger when more elementary schools are available within the district. In districts with above-median school availability, the estimated responses are 3.4 percent at the Acceptable threshold, −2.9 percent at Recognized, and −3.9 percent at Exemplary and none is statistically distinguishable from zero. The estimates in districts with lower school availability are also statistically insignificant and are considerably less precise, particularly at the Acceptable threshold. Figure 7 shows the corresponding RD plots. There seems to be no systematic pattern in which Hispanic LEP enrollment responds more strongly to ratings when more schools are available within the district.

The comparison groups show some evidence of responsiveness in districts with greater school availability, but the pattern is not uniform across groups. At the Acceptable threshold, the point estimates are positive for all four groups in both school-availability environments, while at the Recognized threshold, the estimates are small and mixed in sign. However, none of the estimates are statistically significant. The clearest pattern appears at the Exemplary threshold. Most notably, all non-LEP enrollment increases by 2.6 percent at the Exemplary cutoff in districts with above-median school availability and the estimate is statistically significant at the 1 percent level. The corresponding point estimate is also positive for Hispanic non-LEP students at 3.4 percent but is not statistically significant while the estimate for economically disadvantaged non-LEP

students is only 0.9 percent. In districts with lower school availability, none of the four groups exhibits a precisely estimated enrollment response at the Exemplary cutoff. Thus, the positive Exemplary response among the broader non-LEP population appears concentrated in districts with more elementary schools but there is little evidence that the effect of crossing a rating threshold is systematically larger for Hispanic LEP students in districts with greater school avaialability.

The results in Panel B examine the responses along the dimension of LEP concentration within schools. At the Acceptable threshold, Hispanic LEP enrollment increases by 7.2 percent in schools with an above-median LEP share and the estimate is statistically significant at the 10 percent level. By contrast, the Hispanic LEP point estimate in schools with lower LEP share is negative and imprecisely estimated. Figure 8 makes the contrast visually evident. At the Acceptable threshold, the enrollment of Hispanic LEP students shifts upward in schools with above-median LEP share of students. At higher thresholds, the Hispanic LEP response still remains small and statistically insignificant.

Among the comparison groups, the estimates also indicate greater responsiveness in some high-LEP school environments. At the Acceptable threshold, the enrollment of all groups increase by a large magnitude but the estimates are not significant. At the Exemplary threshold, however, enrollment increases by 3.7 percent for all non-LEP students and by 4.2 percent for economically disadvantaged non-LEP students in above-median schools, and both estimates are statistically significant. The Hispanic non-LEP estimate is also large at 7.7 percent but less precisely estimated. Given the broader enrollment response at above-median LEP share schools, it is likely that fature of the high-LEP school environment may be associated with greater responsiveness to ratings more broadly rather than something that is unique to Hispanic LEP families. At the same time, the Hispanic LEP result is notable because it contrasts with the absense of an average Hispanic LEP response in the full sample.

Table 8 formally compares Hispanic LEP responses across the two school environments. Panel A provides little evidence of systematic heterogeneity by within-district school availability. The estimated above-minus-lower-availability differences are 1.8 percentage points at the Acceptable cutoff, -6.6 percentage points at Recognized, and -6.0 per-

centage points at Exemplary, and none is statistically distinguishable from zero. The estimates therefore provide little support for the hypothesis that limited within-district school availability alone explains the muted average Hispanic LEP response.

Panel B is more interesting given the stronger response in high-LEP schools. The estimated Hispanic LEP response is higher in above-median LEP schools at all three thresholds. The corresponding above-minus-below differences are 12.2 percentage points at the Acceptable threshold, 3.3 percentage points at Recognized, and 5.6 percentage points at Exemplary. These are economically meaningful differences, particularly at the Acceptable margin, and their consistently positive signs are suggestive of greater responsiveness among Hispanic LEP students in schools with larger LEP populations. However, all three differences are imprecisely estimated and statistically indistinguishable from zero.

This section has shown heterogeneity in enrollment response across two dimensions of school environment: choice set of schools and peer similarity with LEP students. As a complementary check on the availability of information about school ratings, Appendix Section A.1 restricts the analysis to schools located in markets with Spanish-language television access. The Hispanic LEP estimate on proportional enrollment change at the Acceptable threshold is 8.0 percent in schools within counties with access to Spanish-language television access, which is close to the estimate for schools with above-median LEP share. Although the former remains imprecisely estimated and does not identify a causal effect of Spanish-language media, it provides additional suggestive evidence that the muted average Hispanic LEP response may conceal greater responsiveness in some environments.

Overall, the heterogeneity analysis provides little evidence that within-district school availability explains the muted average response of Hispanic LEP families. The results by LEP concentration instead point to circumstances under which Hispanic LEP families may be more responsive to ratings. The Hispanic LEP responses are consistently more positive in schools with above-median LEP shares, and the estimated differences are sizable at some thresholds. At the same time, the formal differences are not statistically precise and several non-LEP groups also exhibit positive responses in high-LEP schools.

The results therefore show heterogeneity in the causal effect of the rating across school environments but do not identify a Hispanic LEP-specific mechanism. High-LEP schools differ along several dimensions including school size, urbanicity, economic disadvantage, language-related resources, parental networks, and the availability of other schools. The estimates are consistent with some feature of this broader environment affecting how families encounter or respond to accountability ratings but the available data does not allow me to distinguish among these explanations.

The pattern is still informative in the light of the main results. In the full sample, I find little evidence that Hispanic LEP enrollment responds to accountability ratings even when some non-LEP groups do so. But the heterogeneity results suggest that the muted average response hides settings in which Hispanic LEP families do respond.

6 Conclusion

School accountability ratings are intended to make information about school quality easier for families to use, but their effectiveness depends on whether families can access and act on these signals. This paper studies how families of Limited English Proficient students respond to such ratings using discontinuities generated by the Texas school accountability system. I find little evidence that Hispanic LEP enrollment responds to crossing any of the three rating thresholds while some non-LEP groups show positive responses at particular margins.

The clearest contrast appears at the Exemplary threshold where enrollment and incoming transfers of all non-LEP students increase compared to the negative and imprecise estimates of Hispanic LEP students. More demographically comparable non-LEP groups also show positive responses at the Acceptable threshold but these estimates are less precise and more sensitive to bandwidth specification. Therefore, the results point to a muted response among Hispanic LEP families.

The more important question raised by these results is why Hispanic LEP families appear less responsive to the rating signal even when there is some suggestive evidence of other groups responding to it. A weak response could arise because ratings do not reach or become salient to these families, or they face constraints that limit their ability

to change schools, or they place little weight on the categorical label. The heterogeneity analysis does not clearly distinguish among these explanations. I find little evidence that a larger local choice set of schools alone generates stronger responses. However, I do find a positive response among Hispanic LEP students in schools with high concentration of LEP students, which suggests that some feature of the school environment may matter. These schools differ along several dimensions and data limitation prevent this study from providing a clean interpretation of the mechanism.

The identification of these mechanisms matter for the effectiveness of the school accountability systems. The publication of school ratings provide an easily interpretable signal on school quality but if families facing greater information or choice frictions are seemingly less responsive to it, these policies may not be benefiting all households equally. So, the accountability systems need to consider not only how to effectively summarize school quality information but also how to reach families and whether all households have meaningful opportunities to act on it.

An important direction of future research for the literature on school accountability policies and LEP families is to investigate the source of this muted response to school ratings. Identifying whether it stems from limited information reach, constraints on school choice, or differences in how families perceive school quality will have different policy implications. The appropriate response could range from improving the delivery of school quality information to reducing barriers to switching schools to providing richer information than categorical ratings based on academic performance alone.

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Tables

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics by Student Group

	Hispanic LEP	All Non-LEP	Hispanic Non-LEP	Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP
Panel A. Student and School Characteristics				
Ever Economically Disadvantaged	0.974	0.636	0.848	1.000
Urban School	0.614	0.439	0.568	0.499
Suburban School	0.269	0.337	0.259	0.271
Town/Rural School	0.117	0.224	0.173	0.231
Mean Group Enrollment	154.69	400.15	128.04	254.32
School-Year Observations	15,553	15,793	15,759	15,793
Panel B. Accountability Rating Distribution				
Unacceptable	0.020	0.010	0.009	0.014
Acceptable	0.521	0.343	0.413	0.423
Recognized	0.386	0.454	0.462	0.452
Exemplary	0.073	0.193	0.116	0.111

Notes: This table reports descriptive statistics for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students in Texas elementary schools from 2001 to 2008, excluding 2003. Panel A reports student-weighted school characteristics, except for mean group enrollment, which is the unweighted mean number of students in the corresponding group at the school-year level. The economically disadvantaged share equals one by construction for the economically disadvantaged non-LEP group. School-year observations report the number of observations with positive enrollment for the corresponding group. Panel B reports the student-weighted distribution of each group's enrollment across school accountability rating categories.

Table 2. Balance of Predetermined Characteristics Around Accountability Rating Cutoffs within 8-point Bandwidth

	Acceptable	**Recognized**	**Exemplary**
Panel A. School Characteristics			
Urban School	0.04	-0.02	0.01
	(0.091)	(0.029)	(0.030)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.60	0.46	0.38
Suburban School	0.05	0.03	0.03
	(0.060)	(0.026)	(0.029)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.15	0.27	0.34
Hispanic Share	-0.00	0.00	0.02
	(0.060)	(0.019)	(0.019)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.58	0.51	0.36
LEP Share	0.02	-0.00	0.02
	(0.047)	(0.014)	(0.012)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.38	0.28	0.19
Economically Disadvantaged Share	-0.02	-0.00	-0.00
	(0.047)	(0.015)	(0.016)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.69	0.55	0.41
Panel B. Group-Specific Enrollment Characteristics			
Hispanic LEP			
Enrollment (t)	5.01	-2.98	13.35
	(39.356)	(11.201)	(8.406)
Below-Cutoff Mean	231.63	167.40	98.01
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.05	-0.02	-0.16
	(0.084)	(0.059)	(0.171)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.25	0.24	0.38
All Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	-23.50	17.81*	-12.03
	(27.619)	(10.821)	(12.265)
Below-Cutoff Mean	296.68	389.38	446.85
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	0.02	0.02**	-0.01
	(0.038)	(0.009)	(0.010)
Below-Cutoff Mean	-0.03	-0.01	0.00

Table 2. Balance of Predetermined Characteristics Around Accountability Rating Cutoffs within 8-point Bandwidth (continued)

	Acceptable	Recognized	Exemplary
Panel B. Group-Specific Enrollment Characteristics (continued)			
Hispanic Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	-9.13	6.20	1.69
	(16.277)	(7.351)	(6.887)
Below-Cutoff Mean	102.66	140.92	114.08
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.01	0.03	0.01
	(0.066)	(0.022)	(0.025)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.08	0.10	0.13
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	-10.56	10.76	-1.14
	(23.827)	(7.596)	(7.373)
Below-Cutoff Mean	257.48	275.28	223.45
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	0.02	0.02**	-0.02
	(0.038)	(0.010)	(0.016)
Below-Cutoff Mean	-0.01	0.02	0.04

Notes: Each coefficient reports the estimated difference in the indicated predetermined characteristic at the relevant accountability rating cutoff, comparing schools within 8 percentage points of the cutoff. Positive estimates indicate that the characteristic is higher for schools just above the cutoff than for schools just below it. Panel A reports school-level characteristics, while Panel B reports baseline enrollment and pre-period enrollment growth separately for each student group. The omitted urbanicity category is town/rural. Below-cutoff means within the bandwidth are reported below each estimate. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 3. RDD Estimated Effects of Crossing the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary Cutoffs on Proportional Enrollment Change, by Student Group

	Hispanic LEP	**All Non-LEP**	**Hispanic Non-LEP**	**Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP**
Acceptable	0.027	0.054	0.165**	0.043
	(0.055)	(0.037)	(0.082)	(0.034)
Outcome Mean	0.06	-0.02	0.16	-0.01
Recognized	-0.019	0.005	-0.037	0.006
	(0.039)	(0.008)	(0.024)	(0.009)
Outcome Mean	0.14	-0.01	0.08	-0.00
Exemplary	-0.031	0.019**	0.023	0.007
	(0.046)	(0.007)	(0.023)	(0.012)
Outcome Mean	0.22	-0.01	0.10	0.00

Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating threshold on proportional enrollment change for Hispanic LEP students and the three non-LEP comparison groups. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. The outcome is the proportional change in enrollment between year t and year $t+2$, normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. The numbers of observations at the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary thresholds are 776, 5,737, and 5,438 for Hispanic LEP students; 756, 5,642, and 5,430 for all non-LEP students; 784, 5,811, and 5,540 for Hispanic non-LEP students; and 787, 5,818, and 5,548 for economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 4. Comparison of Proportional Enrollment Change Response Between Hispanic LEP Students and Non-LEP Control Groups

	All Non-LEP	**Hispanic Non-LEP**	**Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP**
Acceptable			
Comparison Group	0.054	0.165**	0.043
	(0.037)	(0.082)	(0.034)
Hispanic LEP	0.027	0.027	0.027
	(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.055)
Difference	-0.027	-0.138	-0.016
	(0.065)	(0.089)	(0.063)
Recognized			
Comparison Group	0.005	-0.037	0.006
	(0.008)	(0.024)	(0.009)
Hispanic LEP	-0.019	-0.019	-0.019
	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)
Difference	-0.024	0.018	-0.025
	(0.040)	(0.045)	(0.039)
Exemplary			
Comparison Group	0.019**	0.023	0.007
	(0.007)	(0.023)	(0.012)
Hispanic LEP	-0.031	-0.031	-0.031
	(0.046)	(0.046)	(0.046)
Difference	-0.050	-0.055	-0.038
	(0.047)	(0.050)	(0.047)

Notes: Each column reports estimates from a separate specification comparing Hispanic LEP students with the comparison group indicated in the column heading. The "Comparison Group" and "Hispanic LEP" rows report the estimated discontinuity in enrollment change for each group. The "Difference" row reports the coefficient on the interaction between Hispanic LEP status and crossing the relevant rating threshold, and therefore measures the Hispanic LEP estimate minus the corresponding comparison-group estimate. Negative differences indicate a smaller enrollment response among Hispanic LEP students. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 5. RDD Estimated effects of crossing the Acceptable, Recognized and Exemplary cutoffs on Enrollment Channels, by Student Group

	Hispanic LEP	**All Non-LEP**	**Hispanic Non-LEP**	**Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP**
Panel A: Incoming Transfer Ratio				
Acceptable	0.033	0.095***	0.177*	0.103***
	(0.050)	(0.029)	(0.107)	(0.031)
Recognized	-0.023	0.003	-0.019	0.002
	(0.026)	(0.008)	(0.019)	(0.009)
Exemplary	-0.034	0.015**	0.006	-0.003
	(0.036)	(0.007)	(0.015)	(0.011)
Panel B: New Entrant Ratio				
Acceptable	0.002	0.016	0.075	0.011
	(0.036)	(0.033)	(0.055)	(0.032)
Recognized	0.005	0.005	-0.015	0.003
	(0.019)	(0.007)	(0.013)	(0.008)
Exemplary	0.007	0.007	0.012	0.003
	(0.025)	(0.006)	(0.014)	(0.008)
Panel C: Leaver Ratio				
Acceptable	0.012	0.041	0.025	0.042
	(0.028)	(0.031)	(0.035)	(0.031)
Recognized	0.007	0.005	0.003	0.001
	(0.009)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.008)
Exemplary	0.008	0.001	-0.002	-0.002
	(0.012)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.006)

Notes: Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The specifications are unweighted. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. Incoming transfers, new entrants, and leavers are normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 6. Descriptive Characteristics by Within-District School Availability and LEP Concentration

	Below Median	Above Median	Difference
Panel A: Within-District School Availability			
Total School Enrollment	342.339	611.636	269.296
LEP Share	0.106	0.288	0.182
Economically Disadvantaged Share	0.547	0.509	-0.038
Hispanic LEP Share	0.102	0.264	0.162
Urban School	0.042	0.525	0.483
Suburban School	0.086	0.318	0.231
Town/Rural School	0.871	0.157	-0.714
Number of Elementary Schools in District	1.000	42.622	41.622
Panel B: LEP Concentration			
Total School Enrollment	516.234	634.440	118.206
LEP Share	0.072	0.453	0.381
Economically Disadvantaged Share	0.441	0.589	0.148
Hispanic LEP Share	0.057	0.426	0.370
Urban School	0.332	0.579	0.247
Suburban School	0.292	0.277	-0.015
Town/Rural School	0.375	0.143	-0.232
Number of Elementary Schools in District	23.295	50.274	26.979

Notes: The table reports unweighted school-year means by school environment. Panel A divides districts according to the number of elementary schools in the administrative district, which is used as a proxy for the set of schooling options available to families. Above-median districts have more elementary schools than the district-level median, while below-median districts have fewer. Panel B divides schools according to their LEP enrollment share. Above-median schools have an LEP share above the sample median, while below-median schools have an LEP share at or below the median. The "Difference" column reports the above-median mean minus the below-median mean. The sample includes Texas elementary schools from 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

Table 7. RDD Estimated Effects of Crossing the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary Cutoffs on Proportional Enrollment Change, by School Environment and Student Group

	Acceptable	Recognized	Exemplary
Panel A: Within-District School Availability			
Above-Median Number of Elementary Schools			
Hispanic LEP	0.034	-0.029	-0.039
	(0.047)	(0.043)	(0.051)
All Non-LEP	0.037	0.006	0.026***
	(0.039)	(0.010)	(0.008)
Hispanic Non-LEP	0.115	-0.030	0.034
	(0.077)	(0.026)	(0.024)
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP	0.032	0.006	0.009
	(0.038)	(0.010)	(0.014)
Below-Median Number of Elementary Schools			
Hispanic LEP	0.017	0.037	0.021
	(0.262)	(0.080)	(0.113)
All Non-LEP	0.106	-0.004	-0.018
	(0.100)	(0.013)	(0.014)
Hispanic Non-LEP	0.325	-0.078	-0.027
	(0.241)	(0.057)	(0.069)
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP	0.076	0.007	-0.001
	(0.078)	(0.015)	(0.018)
Panel B: LEP Concentration			
Above-Median LEP Share			
Hispanic LEP	0.072*	-0.006	0.018
	(0.039)	(0.015)	(0.024)
All Non-LEP	0.046	0.001	0.037**
	(0.044)	(0.013)	(0.015)
Hispanic Non-LEP	0.095	0.006	0.077
	(0.079)	(0.017)	(0.050)
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP	0.036	0.002	0.042***
	(0.043)	(0.013)	(0.016)
Below-Median LEP Share			
Hispanic LEP	-0.050	-0.039	-0.038
	(0.179)	(0.088)	(0.069)
All Non-LEP	-0.018	0.013	0.006
	(0.046)	(0.009)	(0.008)
Hispanic Non-LEP	0.097	-0.076	0.014
	(0.146)	(0.050)	(0.022)
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP	-0.011	0.012	-0.007
	(0.046)	(0.011)	(0.015)

Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating threshold on the enrollment change ratio, separately by student group and school environment. Panel A divides districts according to the number of elementary schools in the administrative district. Above-median districts have more elementary schools than the district-level median, while at/below-median districts have a number of elementary schools at or below the median. Panel B divides schools according to their LEP enrollment share. Above-median schools have an LEP share above the sample median, while at/below-median schools have an LEP share at or below the median. Each estimate is obtained from a separate local-linear RD regression for the corresponding student group and school environment. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8 and are unweighted. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 8. RDD Estimated Effects of Crossing the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary Cutoffs on Proportional Enrollment Change Among Hispanic LEP Students, by School Environment

	Acceptable	**Recognized**	**Exemplary**
Panel A: Within-District School Availability			
Above-Median Number of Elementary Schools	0.034 (0.047)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.039 (0.051)
At/Below-Median Number of Elementary Schools	0.017 (0.262)	0.037 (0.080)	0.021 (0.113)
Difference (Above − At/Below)	0.018 (0.263)	-0.066 (0.091)	-0.060 (0.124)
Panel B: LEP Concentration			
Above-Median LEP Share	0.072* (0.039)	-0.006 (0.015)	0.018 (0.024)
At/Below-Median LEP Share	-0.050 (0.179)	-0.039 (0.088)	-0.038 (0.069)
Difference (Above − At/Below)	0.122 (0.182)	0.033 (0.089)	0.056 (0.073)

Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating cutoff on the enrollment change ratio for Hispanic LEP students across different school environments. Panel A divides districts according to whether the number of elementary schools in the administrative district is above the district-level median or at/below the median. Panel B divides schools according to whether their LEP enrollment share is above the sample median or at/below the median. The above- and at/below-median rows report the separate subgroup RD estimates, corresponding to those reported in Table 7. The "Difference" row reports the estimated difference between the two subgroup effects (Above − At/Below) from a pooled local-linear specification that fully interacts the rating-threshold indicator and running-variable slopes with the school-environment indicator. Standard errors are clustered at the school level and reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8 and are unweighted. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figures

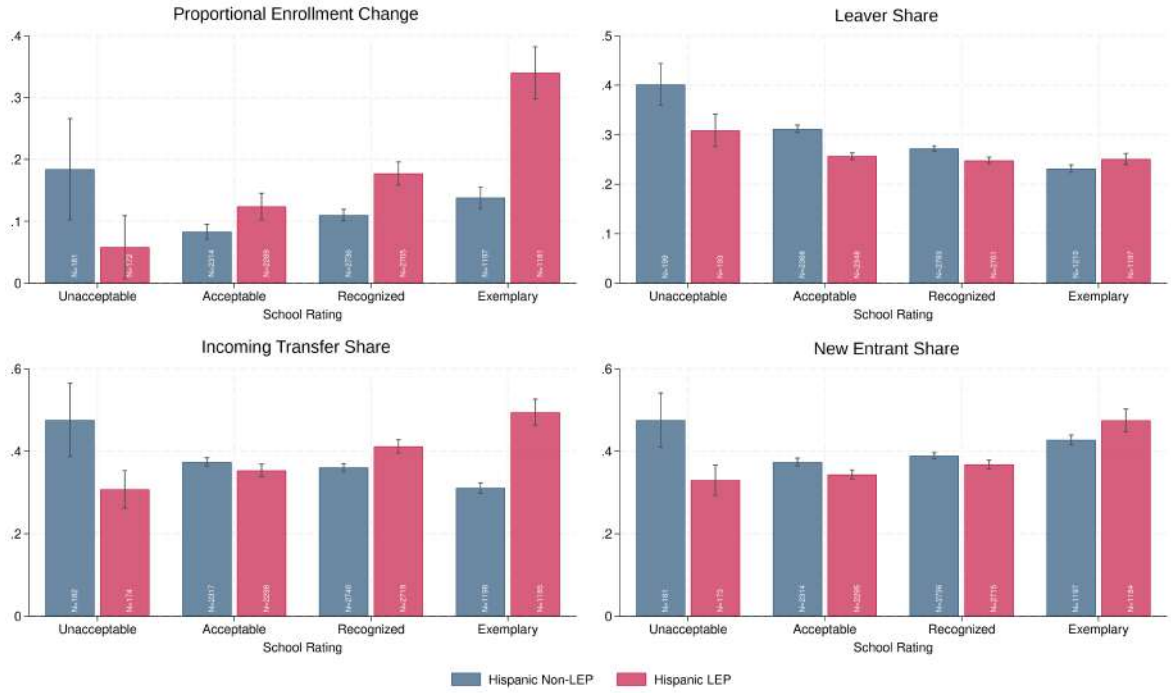


Figure 1. Raw Means by Rating Category and LEP Status

Notes: The figure reports raw mean enrollment outcomes for Hispanic LEP and Hispanic non-LEP students by school accountability rating. Outcomes are measured between the rating year, t, and year $t+2$ and are normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Enrollment change is the proportional change in group enrollment between t and $t+2$. The remaining panels report the shares of year-t enrollment represented by leavers, nonstructural incoming transfers, and new entrants. Leavers exclude students expected to leave because of grade progression, and incoming transfers exclude structural feeder-school moves. Error bars report 95 percent confidence intervals. These are unconditional descriptive means and should not be interpreted as causal effects of school ratings.

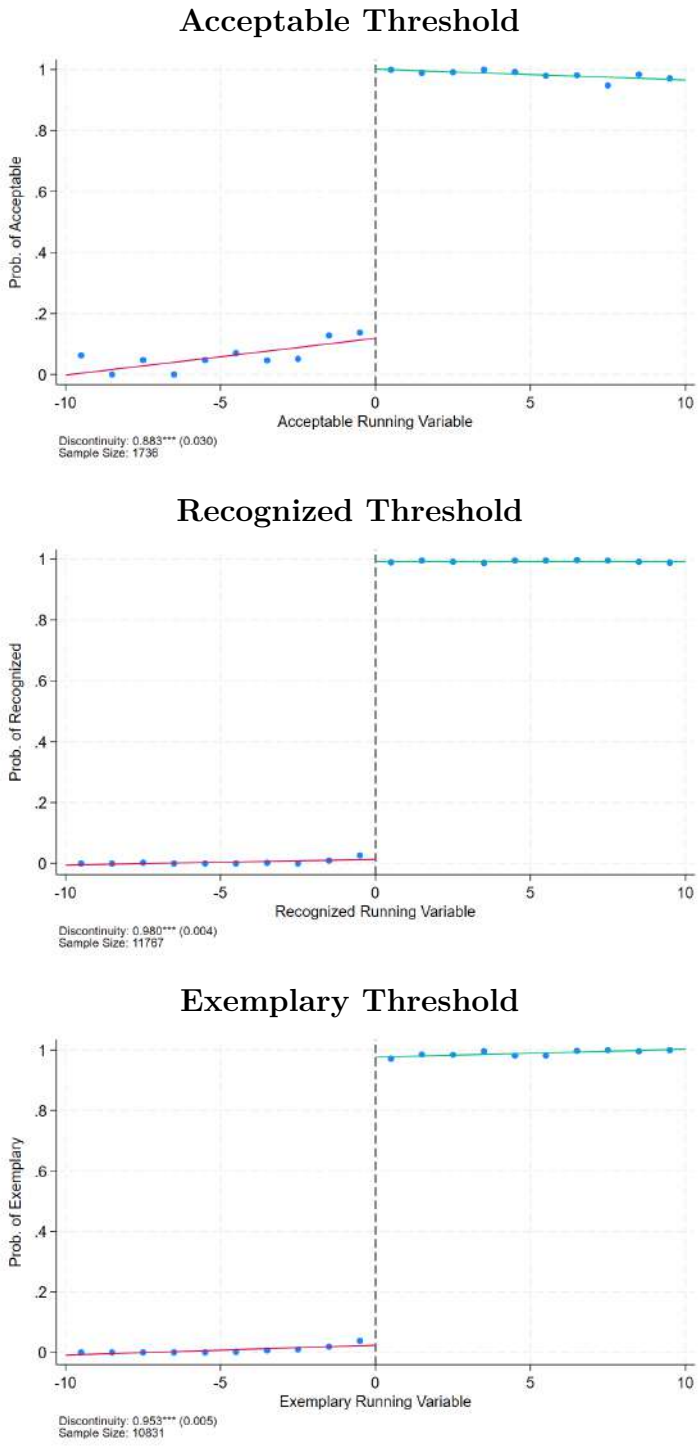


Figure 2. Probability a School Attains a Higher Rating, by Rating Category

Notes: The figure plots the probability that a school receives the higher accountability rating against the running variable at each rating threshold. The running variable is the pass rate of the binding subject–demographic group relative to the applicable statutory cutoff and is normalized to zero at the threshold. Dots report mean rating attainment within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the rating threshold.

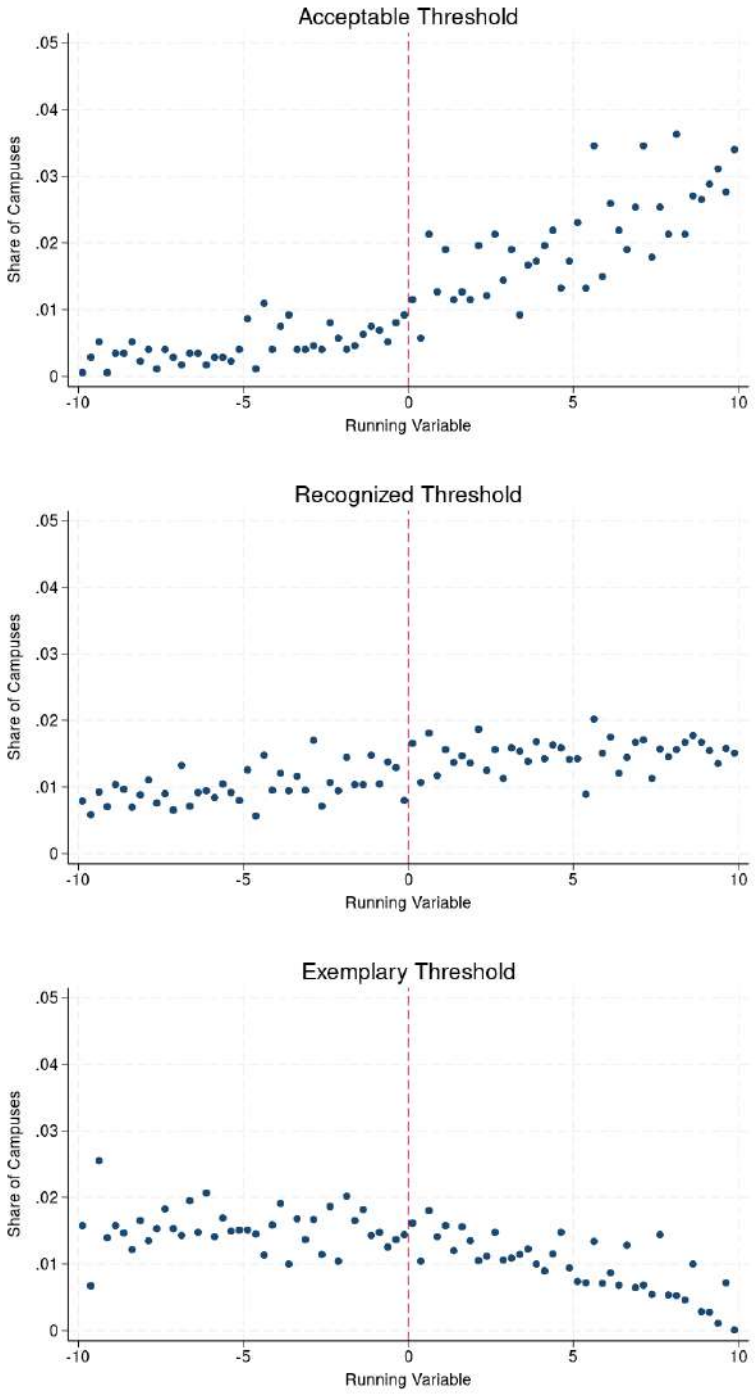


Figure 3. Running variable density, by accountability rating threshold

Notes: The figure plots the distribution of the running variable separately for the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary rating thresholds. The running variable is defined as the pass rate of the binding subject–demographic group minus the applicable statutory cutoff and is therefore centered at zero. Each dot reports the share of campus-year observations falling within a 0.25 percentage-point bin. The dashed vertical line denotes the rating threshold.

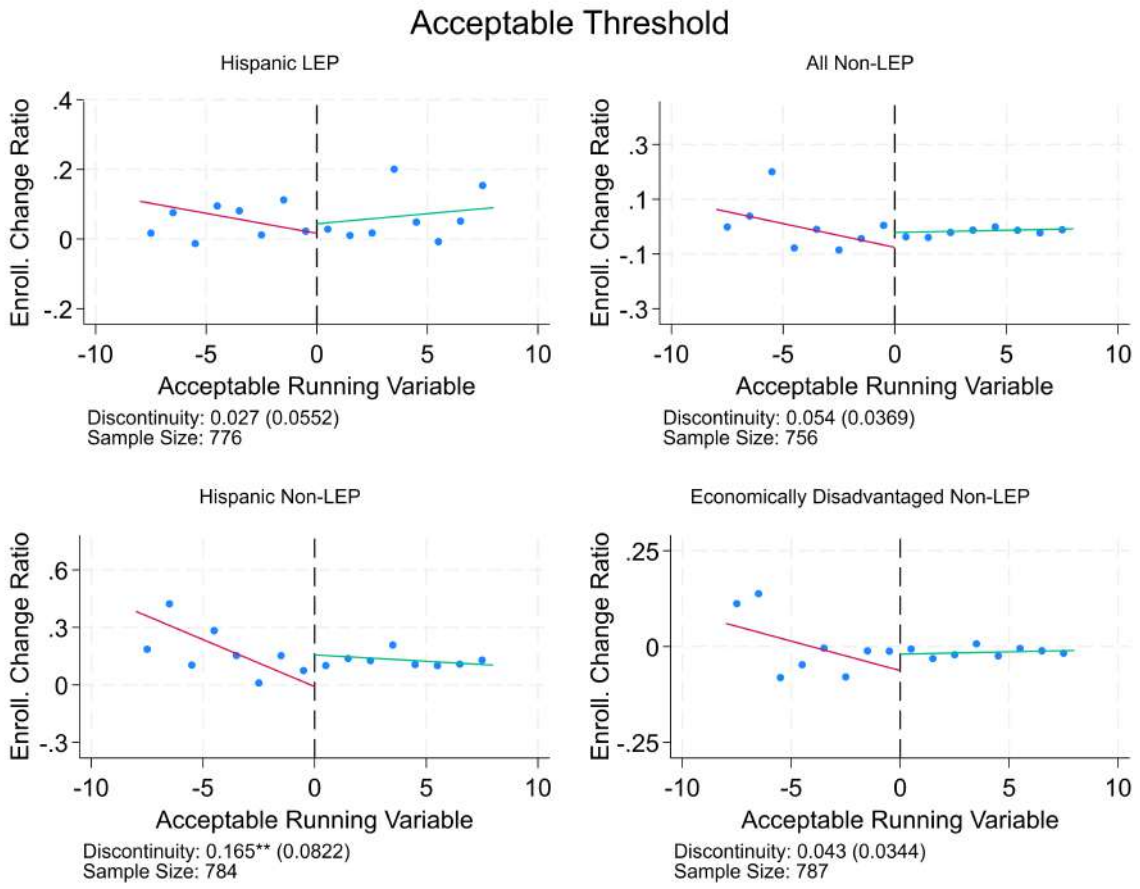


Figure 4. Proportional Enrollment Change Around the Acceptable Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the proportional enrollment change against the centered running variable at the Acceptable rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. Proportional enrollment change is measured between year t and year $t+2$ and is normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

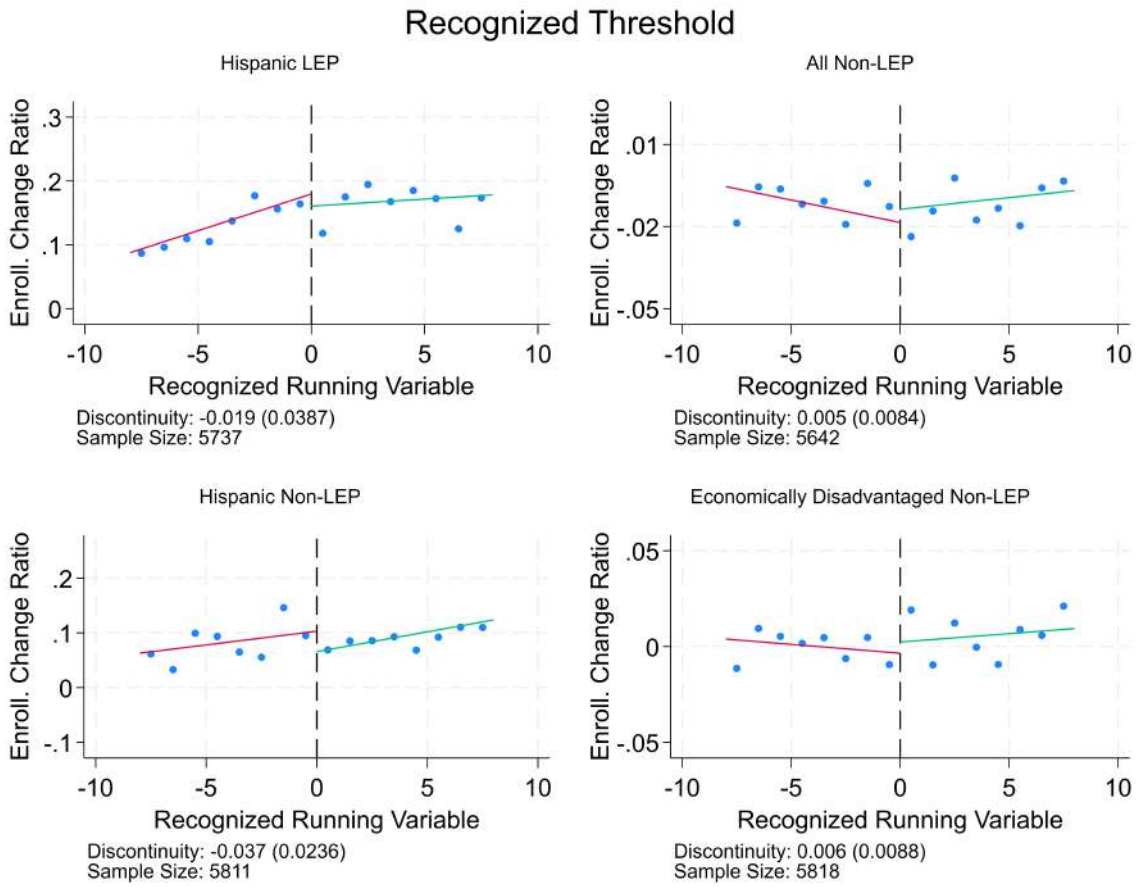


Figure 5. Proportional Enrollment Change Around the Recognized Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the proportional enrollment change against the centered running variable at the Recognized rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. Proportional enrollment change is measured between year t and year $t+2$ and is normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

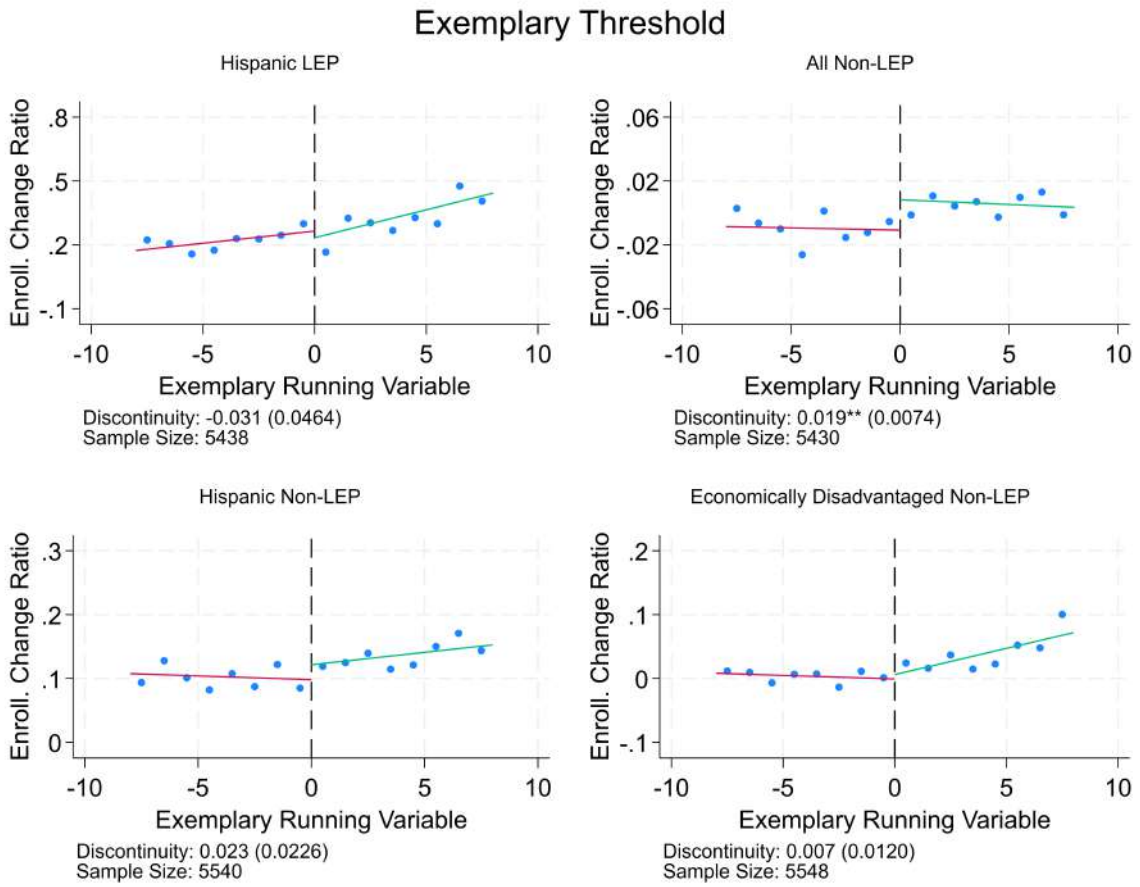


Figure 6. Proportional Enrollment Change Around the Exemplary Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the proportional enrollment change against the centered running variable at the Exemplary rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. Proportional enrollment change is measured between year t and year $t+2$ and is normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

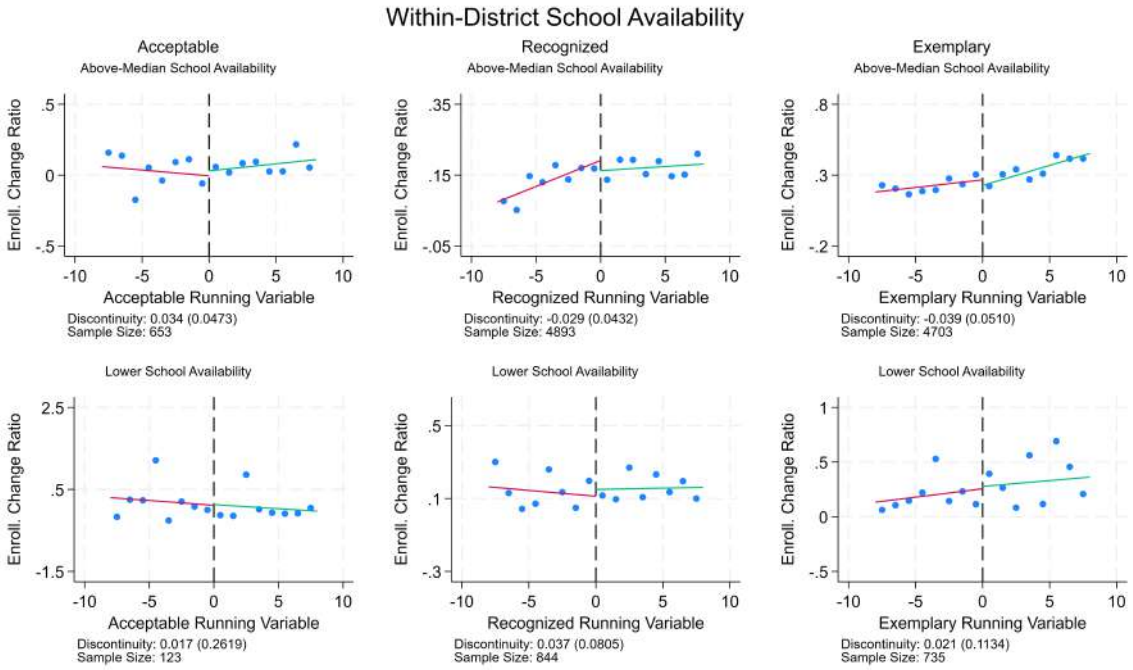


Figure 7. Hispanic LEP Enrollment Responses by Within-District School Availability

Notes: The figure plots the proportional enrollment change for Hispanic LEP students against the centered running variable at the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary rating thresholds, separately by within-district school availability. The top row reports schools in districts with an above-median number of elementary schools, while the bottom row reports schools in districts with an at-or-below-median number of elementary schools. The number of elementary schools in the administrative district is used as a proxy for within-district school availability. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. Proportional enrollment change is measured between year t and year $t+2$ and is normalized by Hispanic LEP enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

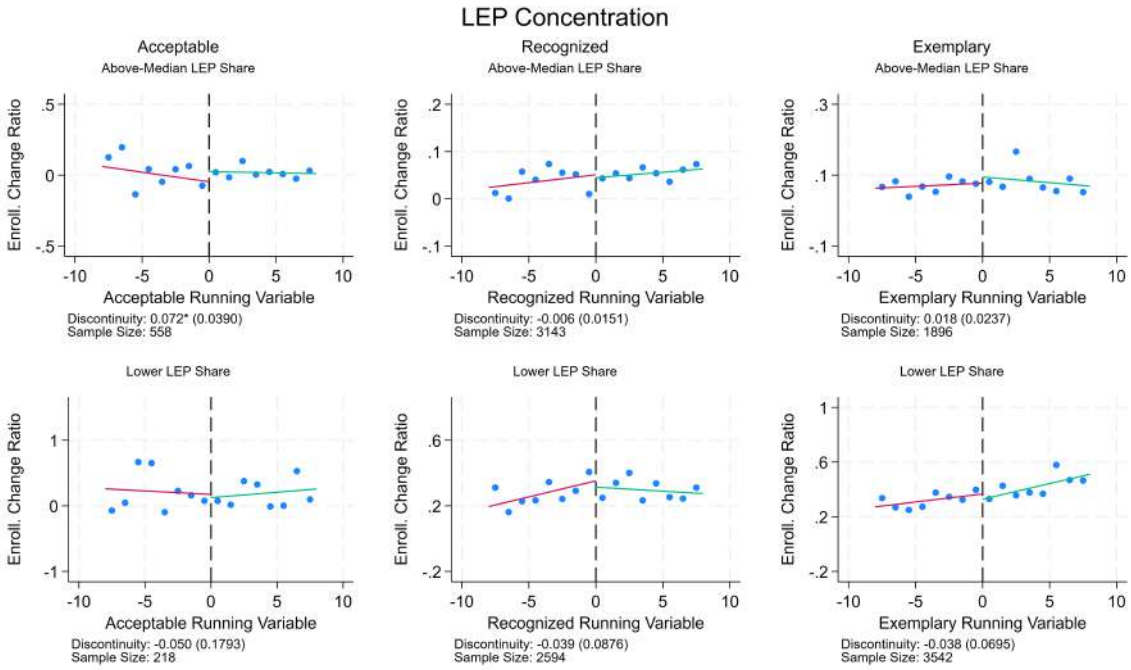


Figure 8. Hispanic LEP Enrollment Responses by LEP Concentration

Notes: The figure plots the proportional enrollment change for Hispanic LEP students against the centered running variable at the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary rating thresholds, separately by school LEP concentration. The top row reports schools with an above-median LEP enrollment share, while the bottom row reports schools with an at-or-below-median LEP enrollment share. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. Proportional enrollment change is measured between year t and year $t+2$ and is normalized by Hispanic LEP enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

A Appendix

A.1 Spanish-Language Television Access and Enrollment Responses

A possible reason for the muted average response among Hispanic LEP families could be lack of awareness about the rating. So, as a complementary exercise to the heterogeneity analysis, I examine whether the enrollment response to accountability ratings looks different in areas with greater access to Spanish-language media. Spanish-language television provides a potentially relevant information environment for Hispanic LEP families because it may increase exposure to locally relevant information in a language that is more accessible to Spanish-speaking households. The analysis is intended to examine whether the main enrollment patterns differ in such markets rather than to identify a causal effect of Spanish-language television access.

I hand-collected data on Spanish-language television availability at the county-level to support this analysis. I identified the station coverage of full-power and Class A Spanish-language television affiliates of Univision, TeleFutura, and Telemundo by Nielsen Designated Market Area (DMA) in Texas between 2000 and 2008. The county-level coverage was consequently obtained by mapping each county to its corresponding DMA. I cross-referenced the station list with the Federal Communications Commission's Consolidated Database System to verify licensing status by year and with station histories and the FCC's 2014 Hispanic Television Study to verify network affiliation. Finally, I construct an indicator equal to one when a county belongs to a Nielsen Designated Market Area (DMA) served during the school year by at least one broadcast affiliate.

The measure captures the presence of a local Spanish-language broadcast affiliate rather than actual viewing, audience share, or exposure to school-rating coverage. Of Texas's 254 counties, 127 lie in a DMA with at least one Spanish-language affiliate throughout the sample period and 127 do not. Spanish-language station availability is highly persistent over the sample window, so the measure is largely cross-sectional and is likely correlated with other characteristics of local markets. I therefore do not interpret differences across these areas as the causal effect of television access.

Table A4 reports the baseline RD estimates after restricting the sample to schools

located in areas with Spanish-language television access.

At the Acceptable threshold, crossing the cutoff is associated with an 8.0 percent increase in Hispanic LEP enrollment in areas with Spanish-language television access compared with a 2.7 percent increase in the full sample from Table 3. However, the estimate remains imprecise and is not statistically distinguishable from zero. Interestingly, for the three non-LEP comparison groups, the estimates in Spanish-language television markets are generally similar to those in the full sample.The enrollment responses are 4.0 percent for all non-LEP students, 13.0 percent for Hispanic non-LEP students, and 3.0 percent for economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. The corresponding full-sample estimates are 5.4, 16.5, and 4.3 percent.

The estimates for both Hispanic LEP and all the comparison groups are also very similar across the two samples at the Recognized and Exemplary thresholds. For Hispanic LEP, the estimated response is -2.0 percent at the Recognized threshold and -4.0 percent at the Exemplary threshold, compared with -1.9 and -3.1 percent, respectively, in the full sample. Similarly, the all non-LEP estimate at the Exemplary threshold, for example, is 2.0 percent in Spanish-language television markets compared with 1.9 percent in the full sample.

This Acceptable-threshold pattern in markets with Spanish-language television aligns with the heterogeneity results in Section 5. The clearest evidence of Hispanic LEP responsiveness in that analysis also occurs at the Acceptable margin as enrollment increases by 7.2 percent in schools with an above-median LEP share. Taken together, these results provide further evidence that the muted average Hispanic LEP response need not characterize every environment in which families encounter the rating. In particular, the positive Acceptable estimates in high-LEP schools and in markets with Spanish-language television access are consistent with greater responsiveness in some settings where Spanish-speaking families may have different information environments.

A.2 Appendix Tables

Table A1. Balance of Predetermined Characteristics Around Accountability Rating Cutoffs within 4-point Bandwidth

	Estimated Difference at Cutoff		
	Acceptable	**Recognized**	**Exemplary**
Panel A. School Characteristics			
Urban School	0.07	-0.04	-0.04
	(0.125)	(0.039)	(0.040)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.58	0.47	0.39
Suburban School	0.08	0.04	0.07**
	(0.082)	(0.035)	(0.038)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.18	0.27	0.33
Hispanic Share	0.10	-0.02	0.01
	(0.082)	(0.025)	(0.024)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.57	0.52	0.37
LEP Share	0.11*	-0.02	0.01
	(0.065)	(0.019)	(0.016)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.39	0.29	0.18
Economically Disadvantaged Share	-0.02	-0.01	0.00
	(0.066)	(0.020)	(0.022)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.70	0.56	0.41
Panel B. Group-Specific Enrollment Characteristics			
Hispanic LEP			
Enrollment (t)	88.69	-16.52	6.02
	(53.931)	(15.512)	(11.461)
Below-Cutoff Mean	227.84	173.12	95.37
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.05	-0.06	-0.30
	(0.097)	(0.085)	(0.245)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.15	0.25	0.41
All Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	-38.50	27.70*	-16.97
	(38.007)	(14.392)	(15.953)
Below-Cutoff Mean	293.12	387.60	442.19
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.03	0.02*	-0.02
	(0.053)	(0.013)	(0.014)
Below-Cutoff Mean	-0.03	-0.01	-0.00

Table A1. Balance of Predetermined Characteristics Around Accountability Rating Cutoffs within 4-point Bandwidth (continued)

	Estimated Difference at Cutoff		
	Acceptable	**Recognized**	**Exemplary**
Panel B. Group-Specific Enrollment Characteristics (continued)			
Hispanic Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	4.13	0.08	-1.77
	(22.065)	(9.806)	(8.641)
Below-Cutoff Mean	100.17	141.09	116.86
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.10	0.04	0.00
	(0.091)	(0.028)	(0.032)
Below-Cutoff Mean	0.06	0.09	0.13
Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP			
Enrollment (t)	-16.24	12.65	-5.37
	(33.493)	(10.288)	(9.549)
Below-Cutoff Mean	255.27	277.13	227.81
Proportional Enrollment Change ($t-2$ to t)	-0.05	0.03**	-0.04
	(0.052)	(0.014)	(0.025)
Below-Cutoff Mean	-0.01	0.02	0.03

Notes: Each coefficient reports the estimated discontinuity in the indicated predetermined characteristic at the relevant accountability rating cutoff, using schools within 4 percentage points of the cutoff. Positive estimates indicate that the characteristic is higher immediately above the cutoff than immediately below it. Panel A reports school-level characteristics, while Panel B reports baseline enrollment and pre-period enrollment growth separately for each student group. The omitted urbanicity category is town/rural. Below-cutoff means within the bandwidth are reported below each estimate. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A2. Robustness of Enrollment Effects to Alternative Bandwidths

	Fixed Bandwidth				Optimal Bandwidth
	4	**6**	**8** *Baseline*	**10**	**Optimal**
Panel A: Hispanic LEP					
Acceptable	-0.015 (0.056)	0.069 (0.065)	0.027 (0.055)	0.015 (0.053)	-0.010 (0.060) [3.50]
Recognized	-0.006 (0.053)	-0.006 (0.045)	-0.019 (0.039)	-0.029 (0.036)	-0.002 (0.043) [6.10]
Exemplary	-0.019 (0.063)	-0.053 (0.056)	-0.031 (0.046)	-0.027 (0.045)	-0.039 (0.074) [2.23]
Panel B: All Non-LEP					
Acceptable	0.009 (0.045)	0.008 (0.037)	0.054 (0.037)	0.013 (0.030)	0.031 (0.040) [6.91]
Recognized	0.016 (0.012)	0.012 (0.010)	0.005 (0.008)	0.002 (0.008)	0.010 (0.010) [5.57]
Exemplary	0.019* (0.010)	0.015* (0.008)	0.019** (0.007)	0.020*** (0.007)	0.020 (0.013) [2.40]

Table A2. Robustness of Enrollment Effects to Alternative Bandwidths (continued)

	Fixed Bandwidth				Optimal Bandwidth
	4	**6**	**8** *Baseline*	**10**	**Optimal**
Panel C: Hispanic Non-LEP					
Acceptable	0.069	0.106	0.165**	0.102	0.069
	(0.098)	(0.091)	(0.082)	(0.070)	(0.098)
					[4.05]
Recognized	-0.023	-0.021	-0.037	-0.034	-0.037
	(0.033)	(0.028)	(0.024)	(0.022)	(0.024)
					[8.02]
Exemplary	0.040	0.015	0.023	0.019	0.037
	(0.028)	(0.025)	(0.023)	(0.021)	(0.029)
					[2.91]
Panel D: Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP					
Acceptable	-0.005	-0.003	0.043	0.006	0.021
	(0.043)	(0.035)	(0.034)	(0.028)	(0.038)
					[6.77]
Recognized	0.021	0.016	0.006	0.003	0.020
	(0.013)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.008)	(0.012)
					[4.15]
Exemplary	0.021	0.012	0.007	0.016	0.018
	(0.013)	(0.011)	(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.018)
					[2.20]

Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating threshold on the enrollment change ratio using alternative bandwidths. Columns (1)–(4) use fixed bandwidths of 4, 6, 8, and 10, respectively. A bandwidth of 8 is used in the baseline specification reported in Table 3. The final column uses the optimal bandwidth selected using the bandwidth selectors for local polynomial regression discontinuity point estimation and inference developed by Calonico et al. (2014). The selected bandwidth is reported in square brackets. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. Specifications follow the baseline RD specification. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A3. Robustness of Incoming Transfer Effects to Alternative Bandwidths

	Fixed Bandwidth				Optimal Bandwidth
	4	**6**	**8** *Baseline*	**10**	**Optimal**
Panel A: Hispanic LEP					
Acceptable	0.027 (0.058)	0.089 (0.057)	0.033 (0.050)	0.051 (0.047)	0.048 (0.059) [3.47]
Recognized	-0.021 (0.034)	-0.020 (0.029)	-0.023 (0.026)	-0.030 (0.024)	-0.022 (0.026) [7.05]
Exemplary	-0.018 (0.049)	-0.045 (0.044)	-0.034 (0.036)	-0.016 (0.034)	-0.012 (0.056) [2.37]
Panel B: All Non-LEP					
Acceptable	0.056 (0.036)	0.078*** (0.029)	0.095*** (0.029)	0.073*** (0.025)	0.043 (0.038) [3.66]
Recognized	0.011 (0.011)	0.008 (0.009)	0.003 (0.008)	0.002 (0.008)	0.007 (0.009) [6.03]
Exemplary	0.012 (0.010)	0.014* (0.008)	0.015** (0.007)	0.022*** (0.007)	0.006 (0.013) [2.35]

Table A3. Robustness of Incoming Transfer Effects to Alternative Bandwidths (continued)

	Fixed Bandwidth				Optimal Bandwidth
	4	**6**	**8** *Baseline*	**10**	**Optimal**
Panel C: Hispanic Non-LEP					
Acceptable	0.080 (0.098)	0.128 (0.082)	0.177* (0.107)	0.131* (0.068)	0.073 (0.100) [3.86]
Recognized	-0.020 (0.026)	-0.017 (0.022)	-0.019 (0.019)	-0.016 (0.017)	-0.017 (0.019) [8.16]
Exemplary	0.022 (0.019)	0.016 (0.017)	0.006 (0.015)	0.013 (0.014)	0.006 (0.024) [1.84]
Panel D: Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP					
Acceptable	0.058 (0.041)	0.088*** (0.032)	0.103*** (0.031)	0.073*** (0.026)	0.083** (0.034) [5.73]
Recognized	0.016 (0.012)	0.009 (0.010)	0.002 (0.009)	0.003 (0.008)	0.010 (0.010) [5.86]
Exemplary	0.009 (0.013)	0.003 (0.011)	-0.003 (0.011)	0.007 (0.010)	-0.001 (0.019) [1.79]

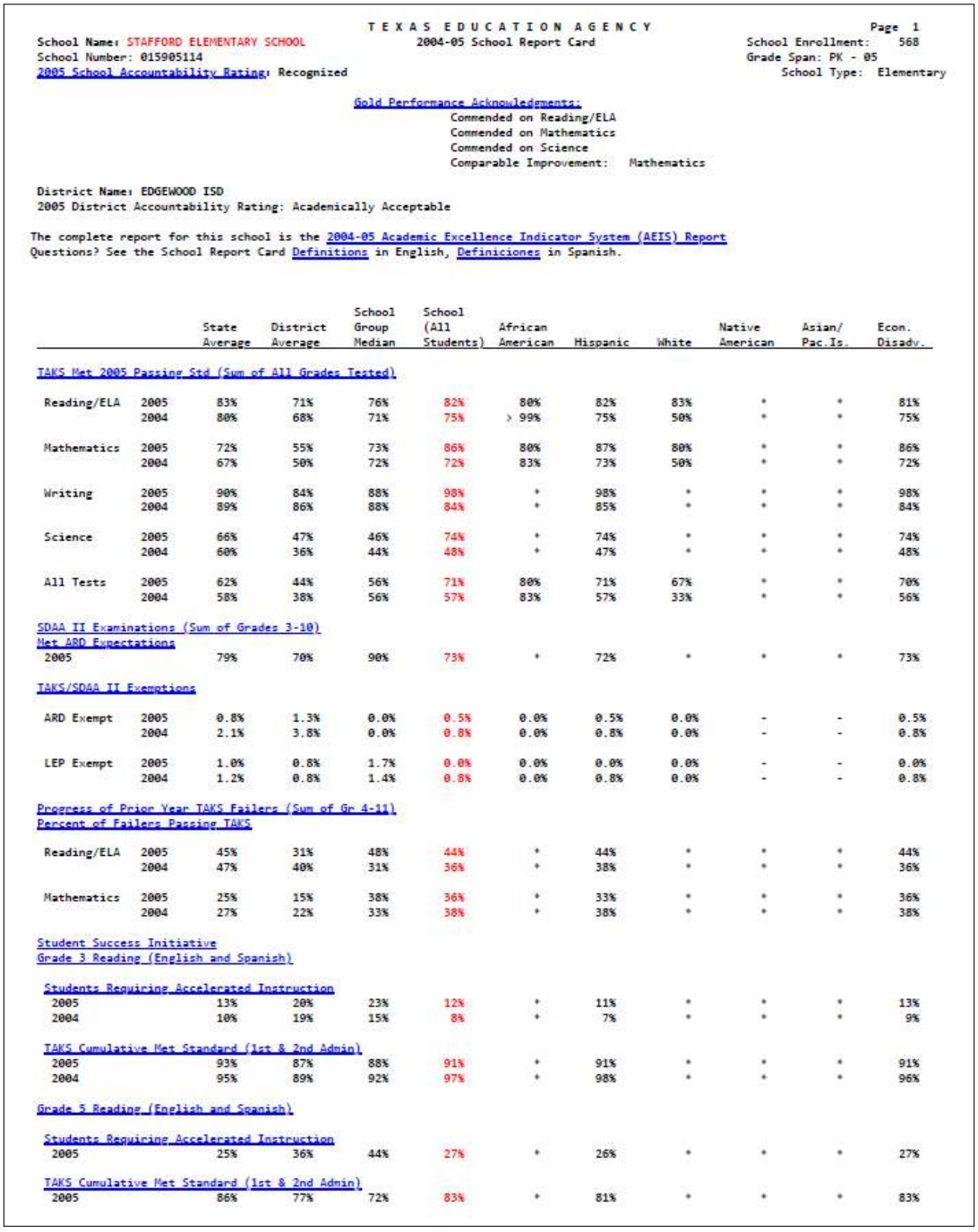
Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating threshold on the incoming transfer ratio using alternative bandwidths. Columns (1)–(4) use fixed bandwidths of 4, 6, 8, and 10, respectively. A bandwidth of 8 is used in the baseline specification reported in Table 5. The final column uses the optimal bandwidth selected using the bandwidth selectors for local polynomial regression discontinuity point estimation and inference developed by Calonico et al. (2014). The selected bandwidth is reported in square brackets. Incoming transfers are normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. Specifications follow the baseline RD specification. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table A4. RDD Estimated Effects of Crossing the Acceptable, Recognized, and Exemplary Cutoffs on Proportional Enrollment Change in Markets with Access to Spanish-Language Television

	Hispanic LEP	**All Non-LEP**	**Hispanic Non-LEP**	**Economically Disadvantaged Non-LEP**
Acceptable	0.080	0.040	0.130	0.030
	(0.063)	(0.039)	(0.084)	(0.039)
Recognized	-0.020	0.000	-0.040	0.000
	(0.041)	(0.010)	(0.026)	(0.011)
Exemplary	-0.040	0.020**	0.020	0.010
	(0.053)	(0.009)	(0.017)	(0.015)

Notes: The table reports RD estimates of the effect of crossing each accountability rating threshold on proportional enrollment change, separately by student group, for schools in areas with Spanish-TV access. Standard errors, clustered at the school level, are reported in parentheses. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8, a local-linear specification, and a uniform kernel. The sample includes observations from 2001–2008, excluding 2003. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

A.3 Appendix Figures



TEXAS EDUCATION AGENCY — Page 1

School Name: STAFFORD ELEMENTARY SCHOOL — 2004-05 School Report Card — School Enrollment: 568
School Number: 015905114 — Grade Span: PK - 05
2005 School Accountability Rating: Recognized — School Type: Elementary

Gold Performance Acknowledgements:
Commended on Reading/ELA
Commended on Mathematics
Commended on Science
Comparable Improvement: Mathematics

District Name: EDGEWOOD ISD
2005 District Accountability Rating: Academically Acceptable

The complete report for this school is the 2004-05 Academic Excellence Indicator System (AEIS) Report
Questions? See the School Report Card Definitions in English, Definiciones in Spanish.

		State Average	District Average	School Group Median	School (All Students)	African American	Hispanic	White	Native American	Asian/ Pac.Is.	Econ. Disadv.
TAKS Met 2005 Passing Std (Sum of All Grades Tested)											
Reading/ELA	2005	83%	71%	76%	82%	80%	82%	83%	*	*	81%
	2004	80%	68%	71%	75%	> 99%	75%	50%	*	*	75%
Mathematics	2005	72%	55%	73%	86%	80%	87%	80%	*	*	86%
	2004	67%	50%	72%	72%	83%	73%	50%	*	*	72%
Writing	2005	90%	84%	88%	98%	*	98%	*	*	*	98%
	2004	89%	86%	88%	84%	*	85%	*	*	*	84%
Science	2005	66%	47%	46%	74%	*	74%	*	*	*	74%
	2004	60%	36%	44%	48%	*	47%	*	*	*	48%
All Tests	2005	62%	44%	56%	71%	80%	71%	67%	*	*	70%
	2004	58%	38%	56%	57%	83%	57%	33%	*	*	56%
SDAA II Examinations (Sum of Grades 3-10) Met ARD Expectations											
	2005	79%	70%	90%	73%	*	72%	*	*	*	73%
TAKS/SDAA II Exemptions											
ARD Exempt	2005	0.8%	1.3%	0.0%	0.5%	0.0%	0.5%	0.0%	-	-	0.5%
	2004	2.1%	3.8%	0.0%	0.8%	0.0%	0.8%	0.0%	-	-	0.8%
LEP Exempt	2005	1.0%	0.8%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	-	-	0.0%
	2004	1.2%	0.8%	1.4%	0.8%	0.0%	0.8%	0.0%	-	-	0.8%
Progress of Prior Year TAKS Failers (Sum of Gr 4-11) Percent of Failers Passing TAKS											
Reading/ELA	2005	45%	31%	48%	44%	*	44%	*	*	*	44%
	2004	47%	40%	31%	36%	*	38%	*	*	*	36%
Mathematics	2005	25%	15%	38%	36%	*	33%	*	*	*	36%
	2004	27%	22%	33%	38%	*	38%	*	*	*	38%
Student Success Initiative Grade 3 Reading (English and Spanish)											
Students Requiring Accelerated Instruction											
	2005	13%	20%	23%	12%	*	11%	*	*	*	13%
	2004	10%	19%	15%	8%	*	7%	*	*	*	9%
TAKS Cumulative Met Standard (1st & 2nd Admin)											
	2005	93%	87%	88%	91%	*	91%	*	*	*	91%
	2004	95%	89%	92%	97%	*	98%	*	*	*	96%
Grade 5 Reading (English and Spanish)											
Students Requiring Accelerated Instruction											
	2005	25%	36%	44%	27%	*	26%	*	*	*	27%
TAKS Cumulative Met Standard (1st & 2nd Admin)											
	2005	86%	77%	72%	83%	*	81%	*	*	*	83%

Figure A1. Example of a Texas School Report Card, 2004–05

Notes: The figure shows an excerpt from a 2004–05 Texas School Report Card. The school's accountability rating appears near the top of the report alongside more detailed measures of student performance.

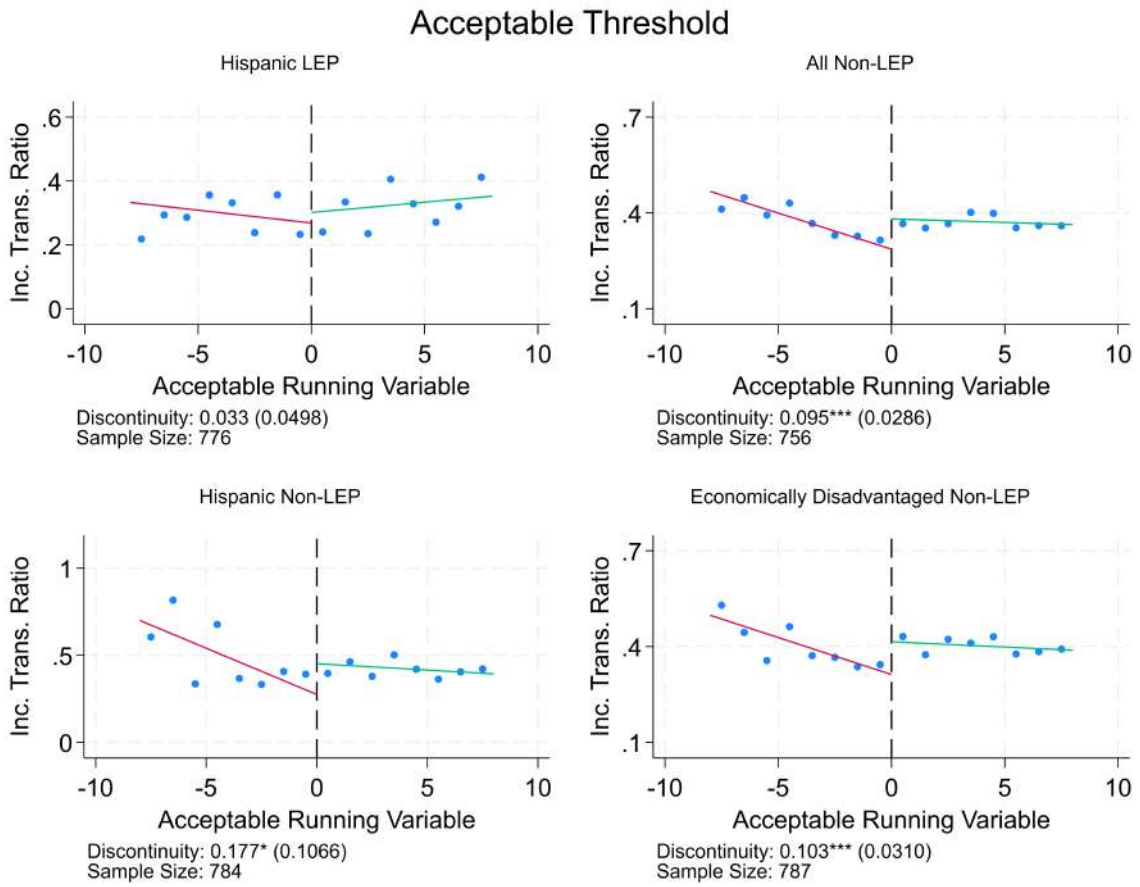


Figure A2. Incoming Transfers Around the Acceptable Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the incoming transfer ratio against the centered running variable at the Acceptable rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. The incoming transfer ratio is the number of nonstructural incoming transfers between year t and year $t+2$, normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

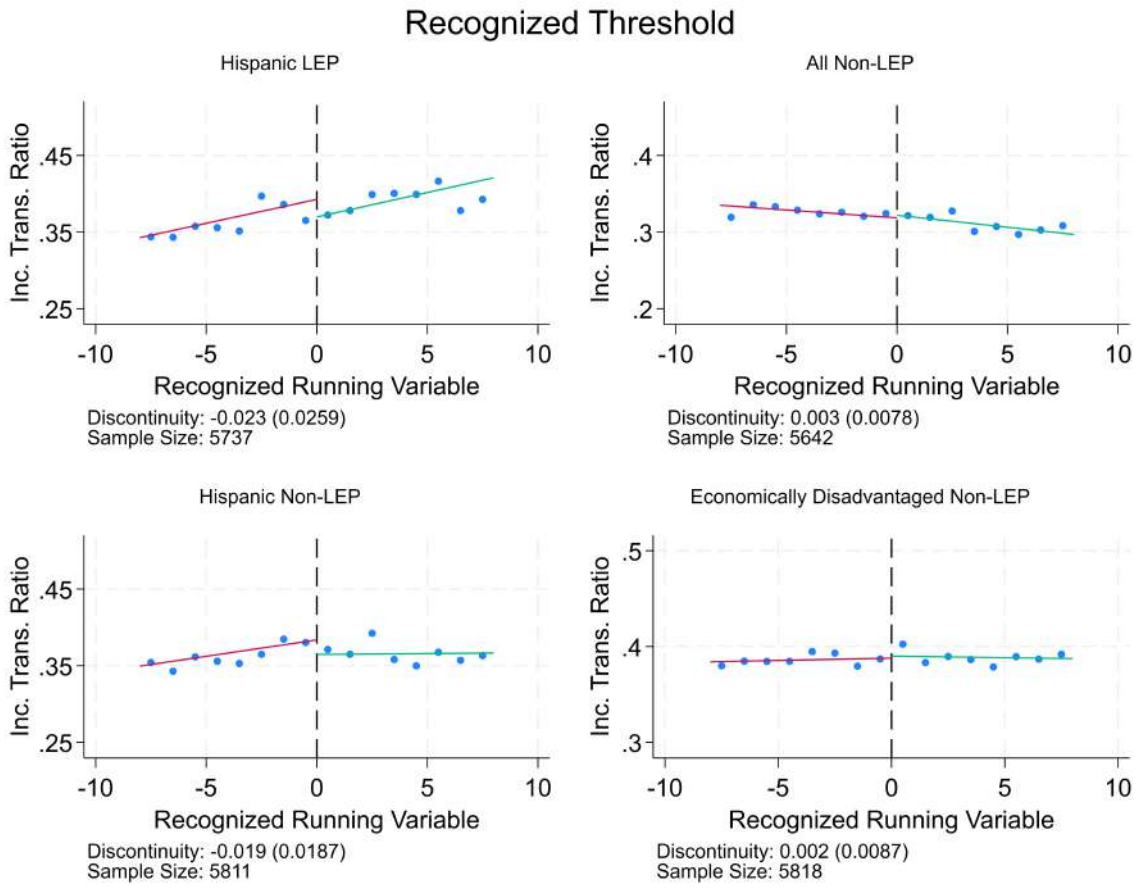


Figure A3. Incoming Transfers Around the Recognized Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the incoming transfer ratio against the centered running variable at the Recognized rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. The incoming transfer ratio is the number of nonstructural incoming transfers between year t and year $t+2$, normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.

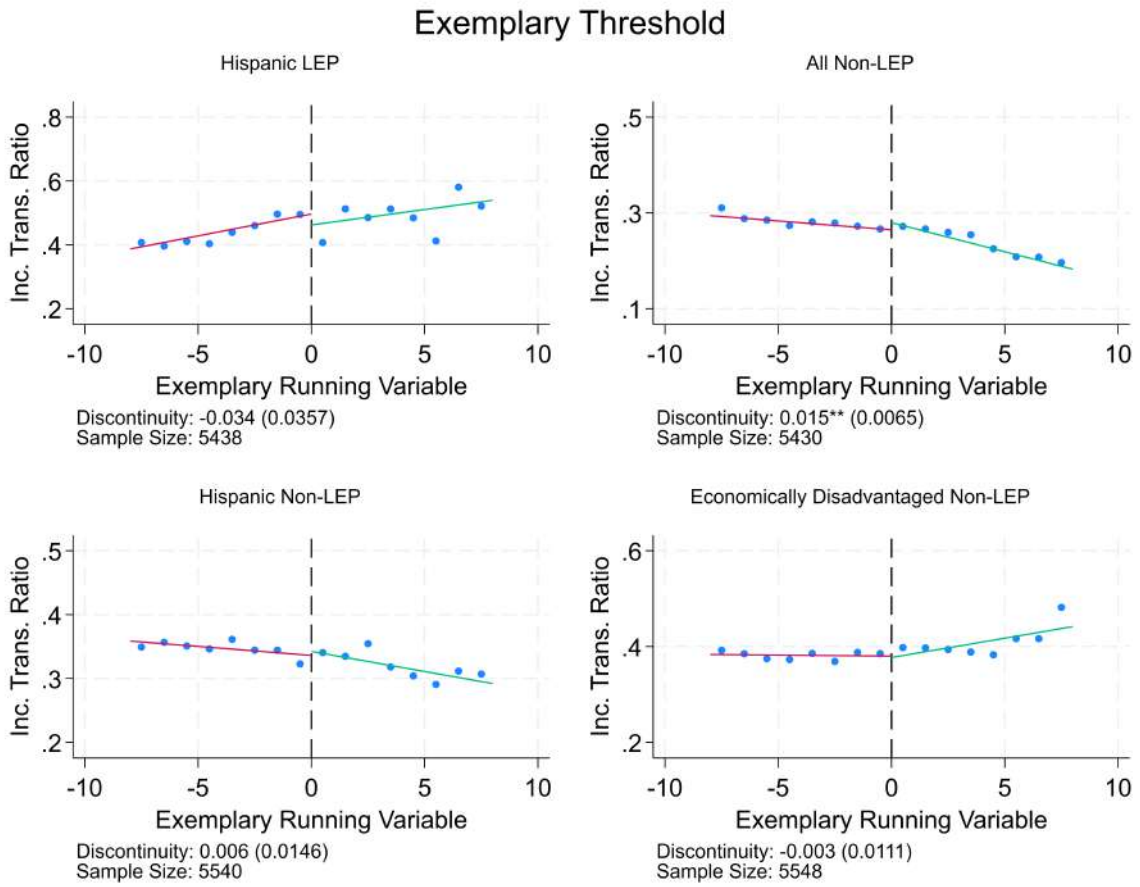


Figure A4. Incoming Transfers Around the Exemplary Rating Threshold, by Student Group

Notes: The figure plots the incoming transfer ratio against the centered running variable at the Exemplary rating threshold separately for Hispanic LEP, all non-LEP, Hispanic non-LEP, and economically disadvantaged non-LEP students. Dots show mean outcomes within bins of the running variable, and solid lines show separate linear fits on either side of the cutoff. The dashed vertical line denotes the statutory rating threshold. The incoming transfer ratio is the number of nonstructural incoming transfers between year t and year $t+2$, normalized by the corresponding group's enrollment in year t. Each panel reports the estimated discontinuity at the cutoff, with the school-clustered standard error in parentheses, and the number of school-year observations. RD estimates use a bandwidth of 8. The sample covers 2001–2008, excluding 2003.